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Focus on women's safety: CM



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TN Cabinet: CM Vijay to helm general admin, police, women, youth welfare



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'You don't let noise get to you'

'INDIA'S ASPIRATIONS NO LONGER LIMITED TO ITS BORDERS'

PM warns of global poverty threat, pitches India as land of opportunity and growth

MPOST BUREAU

THE HAGUE: Prime Minister Narendra Modi used a high-profile address to the Indian diaspora in the Netherlands on Saturday to deliver a dual message: a sobering warning that global crises threaten to reverse decades of poverty reduction worldwide, and an ambitious pitch that India, amid this turbulence, stands ready to become an engine of growth for the planet.

Speaking for over 40 minutes at a community event in The Hague, the second stop on his five-nation European tour, Modi told the gathering that the present decade had become a succession of catastrophes, beginning with the COVID-19 pandemic, followed by armed conflicts, and now an energy crisis worsened by hostilities in West Asia.

"First came the corona-virus pandemic; then wars



Prime Minister Narendra Modi greets during a community programme, in The Hague, Netherlands

PTI

began to break out, and now there is an energy crisis. This decade is turning into a decade of disasters for the world," he said in Hindi.

He warned that without a change in course, the cost would

be generational. If these situations are not rapidly changed, he said, "achievements of the past many decades would be washed away, and a huge section of the world's population would be pushed back into poverty."

Despite that warning, much of Modi's address focused on India's direction. He described the country as going through "unprecedented transformation" and said its goals now extend well

beyond its borders. "India of the 21st century is a land of opportunities. India is both technology-driven and humanity-driven," he told the crowd.

He pointed to numbers to

back the claim. India had four unicorns in 2014. That number has grown to nearly 125 today. The country now ranks as the world's third-largest startup ecosystem. Modi also cited India's

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KEY POINTS

» Modi called this decade a "decade of disasters" citing the pandemic, wars, and energy crisis

» He warned ongoing crises could push a large section of the world's population back into poverty

» Modi described India as undergoing "unprecedented transformation" with goals beyond its borders

» Modi called the Netherlands India's "natural gateway" into Europe for business

» THE TWO COUNTRIES ARE COLLABORATING ON GREEN HYDROGEN, WATER SECURITY, AND ENERGY SECURITY

HOURS AFTER HC REFUSES BAIL

Union minister Bandi Sanjay Kumar's son arrested in POCSO case

MPOST BUREAU

HYDERABAD: Bandi Bhageerath Sai, the 25-year-old son of Union Minister of State for Home Affairs Bandi Sanjay Kumar, was arrested in Narsingi, a satellite town on the outskirts of Hyderabad, on Saturday night in connection with a case filed under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act. The arrest came after the Telangana High Court refused to grant him interim protection, police issued a look-out circular, and teams were deployed across the country to find him.

The case was registered on May 8 based on a complaint filed by the mother of a 17-year-old girl. She alleged that Bhageerath had entered into a relationship with her daughter in June 2025 after making false promises of marriage, and had subjected the girl to inappropriate physical acts and pressured her to consume alcohol between October 2025 and January 2026. According to the FIR, the relationship ended on January 7, after which the girl allegedly attempted to harm herself twice later that month.

After the survivor's statement was recorded before a magistrate on Saturday, more stringent sections of the POCSO Act, including penetrative sexual assault, were added to the case. Statements are recorded before magistrates to ensure accounts are reliably documented and to prevent changes in testimony during trial.

The minister, a BJP MP from Telangana, said he chose to hand his son over to police despite court proceedings being underway and orders expected the following Monday. "With utmost respect for the law and judiciary, today my son Bandi Bhageerath went before the Telangana Police through our advocates



HIGHLIGHTS

» Case registered May 8 under POCSO Act and Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita sections

» A 17-year-old girl's mother filed the complaint alleging sexual harassment and assault

» Alleged relationship began June 2025 after false promises of marriage, family claims

» Girl allegedly pressured to consume alcohol between October 2025 and January 2026

» Girl reportedly attempted self-harm twice after relationship ended January 7

» Bhageerath filed counter-complaint alleging honey-trap and extortion of Rs 5 crore

for investigation," he wrote on X. "Whether it is my own son or a common citizen, everyone is equal before the law."

He said that following the complaint, he had initially considered taking Bhageerath directly to a police station, but lawyers who reviewed the available evidence advised that the case would likely be dismissed and bail obtained without difficulty. That legal advice led to the delay in appearing before investigators. "However, I felt it was not right to delay any further," the minister said, adding that he had complete faith in the judiciary.

Bhageerath has maintained throughout that he did nothing wrong and that the case is the

Continued on P4

Govt to SC: Constitution doesn't mandate judicial representation on EC appointment committee

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The central government has told the Supreme Court that the Constitution does not require a judicial member on the committee that appoints the chief election commissioner and election commissioners. In an affidavit filed on May 13, the government said including a representative from the judiciary on such a panel is "a legislative choice, not a constitutional imperative".

The submission was made in response to a batch of petitions challenging the constitutional validity of the Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023, which came into force on January 2, 2024.

Under the law, the President appoints the chief election commissioner and election commissioners on the recommendation of a three-member selection committee comprising the Prime Minister, a Union Cabinet minister, and the Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha. The law replaced the Chief Justice of India on the selection panel with a Union Cabinet minister.

The government said any argument that judicial participation is necessary to validate appointments "misconceives the separation of powers and Parliament's role under Article 324," the constitutional provision that vests superintendence, direction and control of elections in an Election Commission.

Continued on P4

According to the affidavit, the independence of the Election Commission does not rest on who sits on its appointment committee

COURT SENDS KULKARNI, WAGHMARE TO 10-DAY CBI CUSTODY

NEET paper leak: Biology lecturer, part of NTA's paper-setting committee, arrested

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Central Bureau of Investigation on Saturday arrested a biology lecturer who sat on the National Testing Agency's paper-setting committee for the NEET-UG examination, while a Delhi court sent the case's alleged mastermind and another accused to CBI custody for ten days.

Manisha Gurunath Mandhare, a biology lecturer from Pune, was taken into custody after questioning at CBI headquarters in New Delhi. Investigators say she had been formally appointed by the NTA as a subject expert and, as a result, held unrestricted access to the Botany and Zoology question



papers. Her arrest is the third in as many days in a case that forced the cancellation of an examination that nearly 23 lakh students had registered for across 551 cities in India and 14 overseas centres.

KEY POINTS

» Mandhare served on NTA's paper-setting committee with full access to Botany and Zoology papers

» She allegedly ran coaching classes at her Pune home, dictating leaked questions to select students

» Students paid lakhs in fees; most dictated questions matched the May 3 exam paper exactly

» Alleged kingpin P V Kulkarni, chemistry lecturer from Latur, arrested Friday; had years of NTA access

» Both accused allegedly worked through Manisha Waghmare, arrested May 14, to gather student candidates

» Delhi court grants CBI 10-day custody of Kulkarni and Waghmare for interrogation

According to officials, Mandhare allegedly put that access to criminal use. In April 2026, she is said to have gathered prospective NEET candidates through Manisha Waghmare, a Pune resident

who was herself arrested on May 14. At her Pune home, Mandhare then conducted what investigators describe as "special coaching classes" where she dictated leaked questions

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Govt imposes import curbs on silver, puts metal under licence

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The government moved swiftly on Saturday to further restrict silver imports, placing the metal under a licensed regime just days after raising import duties on precious metals to their highest levels in years.

The Directorate General of Foreign Trade announced that the import policy for silver, including silver plated with gold and platinum, has been revised "from free to restricted with immediate effect," meaning importers will now require a government-issued license to bring the metal into the country. The new

rules, however, carve out exemptions for 100 per cent Export Oriented Units and Special Economic Zone units, provided the imported goods are not sold in the domestic market.

The move follows a May 13 decision to hike import duties on gold and silver from 6 per cent to 15 per cent. With a 3 per cent Integrated GST on top, the effective duty burden now exceeds 18 per cent. The Centre cited the need to stem foreign exchange outflows by curbing non-essential imports. The urgency is rooted in hard numbers. Silver imports more than doubled to USD 411 million in April alone.

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SHE WAS TMC CANDIDATE FROM RAJGANJ

Asian Games gold medalist Swapna Barman seeks police protection after arson, gang rape threats

RAJDEEP MONDAL

JALPAIGURI: Swapna Barman, the first Indian heptathlete to win a gold medal at the Asian Games and the TMC candidate of Rajganj Assembly for the recently concluded Assembly election, has lodged a complaint at the Jalpaiguri Kotwali Police Station seeking police protection after allegedly receiving threats of gang rape along with an incident of arson at her residence in Jalpaiguri.



The incident, which reportedly took place on Friday night, has triggered political reactions

TAKEAWAYS

» 'Had I known this would happen, I truly would not have come into politics. Today, they even set my house on fire'

» On Saturday, Swapna Barman formally submitted a complaint at the police station seeking security for herself and her family

» 'If such situations arise after losing an election, then will any other woman come forward in future? I never thought politics would be like this, but I will continue my struggle'

» 'No one was staying in Swapna Barman's old tin-roofed house. A stockpile of firewood kept beside the house had caught fire and was later extinguished by the fire brigade'

and widespread discussion on social media. Minister of the Department of Women &

Child Development and Social Welfare, Government of West Bengal,

Continued on P4

DETAILED TEACHING GUIDELINES BY JUNE 15

CBSE makes three-language study compulsory in Class 9 from July 1

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Students entering Class 9 this academic year will study three languages under a sweeping curriculum overhaul announced by the Central Board of Secondary Education, with the board softening the transition by exempting the third language from board examinations entirely.

A circular issued on May 15, 2026, confirmed that from July 1, all CBSE-affiliated schools must include three languages, labelled R1, R2 and R3, as compulsory subjects for Class 9 students. The change, which takes effect in the 2026-27 academic session that has already begun, aligns CBSE's Scheme of Studies with the National Education Policy 2020 and the National Curriculum Framework for School Education 2023.

At the heart of the policy is a firm

KEY POINTS

» Three languages will be labelled R1, R2, and R3

» At least two of the three languages must be native Indian languages

» Foreign languages permitted only as the third language or an additional fourth subject

» No board examination will be held for the third language, R3, at Class 10 level

» R3 assessments will be school-based & internal

requirement: at least two of the three languages must be native Indian languages. Students wishing to study a foreign language retain that option, but only as the third language after choosing two Indian languages, or as an additional fourth subject altogether.

"With effect from July 1, 2026, for



» R3 performance will appear on CBSE certificates but won't block board exam entry

» Class 9 students will temporarily use Class 6 R3 textbooks until new ones are ready

Class IX, the study of three languages (R1, R2, R3) shall be compulsory, with at least two languages being native Indian languages," the circular stated.

The board's decision to shield the third language from board-level scrutiny is perhaps its most consequential concession to students.

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India rejects Hague arbitration ruling on Indus Waters Treaty, calls court illegally constituted

Says Indus Waters Treaty is in abeyance

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India on Saturday dismissed a ruling issued by the Permanent Court of Arbitration in The Hague related to hydroelectric projects in Jammu and Kashmir, calling the tribunal illegally formed and its decisions without legal standing.

The court, which had been hearing Pakistan's objections to India's Kishenganga and Ratle hydropower projects under the 1960 Indus Waters Treaty, issued what it described as an award on May 15 addressing maximum pondage, supplemental to an earlier ruling on the treaty's general interpretation.

Ministry of External Affairs Spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said New Delhi has never accepted the tribunal's legitimacy. "India categorically rejects the present so-called award, just as it

Continued on P4

'Did not criticise youth': CJI clarifies 'cockroaches' remarks, says 'pained' over media reports

Says remark was directed at fake degree holders

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Saturday moved to set the record straight over remarks he made in court a day earlier, saying he was hurt by how a section of the media had reported his words.

"I am pained to read how a section of the media has misquoted my oral observations made during the hearing of a frivolous case yesterday," the CJI said in a written statement. The controversy stemmed from a Friday hearing in which Justice Kant used the words "parasites" and "cockroaches" while pulling up a lawyer who had filed a plea seeking senior designation. The remarks quickly drew attention, with some reports suggesting the Chief Justice had targeted the country's youth.

Kant was firm in pushing back



against that reading. His words, he clarified, were aimed squarely at those who have entered the legal profession using fake and bogus degrees, a problem he said extends beyond the Bar to media, social media, and other fields.

"It is totally baseless to suggest that I criticised the youth of our nation. Not only am I proud of our present and future human resource, but every youth of India inspires me," he said.

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‘WPI inflation to rise further as oil, metal prices stay elevated’

If a peace deal is not reached soon, prolonged tensions could keep fuel inflation high, while a depreciating rupee may add to import costs

NEW DELHI: With the US-Iran conflict keeping global crude oil prices elevated and the Strait of Hormuz disruption pushing up metal costs, the economic research wing of Bank of Baroda sees further upside pressure on headline WPI in the coming months.

If a peace deal is not reached soon, prolonged tensions could keep fuel inflation high, while a depreciating rupee may add to import costs. Food inflation, which is still providing a cushion, may also inch up depending on the progress of the monsoon.

India's Wholesale Price Index (WPI) inflation accelerated sharply to 8.3 per cent in April 2026, its highest level since October 2022, compared with just 0.9 per cent in April 2025 and 3.9 per cent in March 2026. The surge was driven primarily by fuel and manufactured products, even as food inflation remained relatively muted.

Fuel and power inflation jumped to a 42-month high of 24.7 per cent in April 2026, up from a contraction of 3.8 per cent a year ago and 1.1 per cent



Food inflation, which is still providing a cushion, may also inch up depending on the progress of the monsoon

in March 2026.

The mineral oil index led the rise, surging 39.5 per cent YoY against a decline of 5.6 per cent last year. Within mineral oils, aviation turbine fuel saw a more than 100 per cent YoY increase, followed by sharp gains in naphtha, furnace oil, petrol, kerosene, and diesel. Coal inflation also edged up to 1.4 per cent from 0.1 per cent.

The spike reflects a 54.2 per cent YoY rise in international crude oil prices in April 2026,

worsened by rupee depreciation and escalating geopolitical tensions in the Gulf.

Manufactured products inflation climbed to 4.6 per cent, the highest since September 2022, compared with 2.6 per cent in April 2025 and 3.4 per cent in March 2026. Of the 22 sub-indices, 13 recorded faster growth, led by basic metals, machinery and equipment, textiles, chemicals, pharmaceuticals, and other manufacturing. Aluminium prices rose 19.2

Highlights

- » India's WPI inflation accelerated sharply to 8.3 per cent in April 2026, its highest level since October 2022
- » The surge was driven by fuel & manufactured products, even as food inflation remained relatively muted
- » Fuel and power inflation jumped to a 42-month high of 24.7 per cent in April 2026

per cent YoY versus 3.9 per cent last year, while copper held steady at 15.3 per cent. Zinc inflation eased marginally to 6.3 per cent, and lead moderated to 1.1 per cent. Internationally, metal prices have risen even more sharply, with aluminium up 51.8 per cent YoY and copper up 41.1 per cent.

As a result, core WPI inflation reached 5 per cent in April 2026, a 43-month high, up from 1.2 per cent a year ago and 3.7 per cent in March 2026.

In contrast, food inflation provided some relief, easing to 2.3 per cent in April 2026 from 3.3 per cent in April 2025. This was due to weak foodgrain inflation at -1 per cent YoY, led by a decline in cereals (0.3 per cent vs 3.9 per cent) and continued deflation in pulses (-4 per cent vs -5.6 per cent). Wheat inflation slowed sharply to 0.4 per cent from 7.4 per cent.

However, vegetables, milk, and eggs/meat/fish registered higher inflation. Vegetable inflation rose to 0.5 per cent from -17.2 per cent last year on a base effect, with tomatoes, ginger, cauliflower, and cabbage driving the uptick. Milk inflation increased to 2.6 per cent from 1.1 per cent, while eggs, meat and fish inflation surged to 6.7 per cent from -0.3 per cent.

The research report notes that while domestic foodgrain inflation remains weak, international prices tell a different story, with wheat up 12.6 per cent YoY in April 2026 and the pace of rice price decline slowing to -3.2 per cent from -31 per cent. This divergence could feed into domestic food prices in the months ahead.

AGENCIES

₹ decline can wipe out gains from fuel price hike, says SBI Research

NEW DELHI: The rupee has reached a critical level where any further depreciation could wipe out the gains from the recent Rs 3 per litre increase in petrol and diesel prices, according to an SBI Research Ecowrap report.

The report warned that "even an additional depreciation of Rs 2 in the Rupee raises the effective crude oil price, pushing the landed import cost, which fully offsets the gains from the current fuel price hike."

The SBI Research report said the recent fuel price hike was aimed at reducing losses faced by Oil Marketing Companies (OMCs) due to elevated crude oil prices and unchanged retail fuel prices.

"OMCs' under recoveries on sales of petrol and diesel are soaring because of unchanged retail prices," the report said. It added that OMCs are "incurring losses to the tune of Rs 1000 crore per day, which amounts to around Rs 3.6 lakh crore a year."

According to the report, the Rs 3 per litre increase in fuel prices is expected to provide relief of around Rs 52,700 crore to OMCs, covering only around 15 per cent of their estimated FY27 losses.

Highlighting the pressure from currency weakness, the report said, "the Rupee has already approached a critical depreciation threshold, beyond which further currency weakness could substantially erode the intended benefits of domes-



'The recent fuel price hike was aimed at reducing losses faced by OMCs due to elevated crude oil prices and unchanged retail fuel prices'

tic fuel price revisions."

The report estimated that, assuming an average FY27 exchange rate of Rs 94 per US dollar and crude oil prices at \$106 per barrel, the landed crude oil cost works out to nearly Rs 9,964 per barrel. It said the Rs 3 fuel price increase provides a benefit of around Rs 477 per barrel to OMCs, but a further Rs 2 depreciation in the Rupee significantly raises import costs.

SBI Research also said India needs a broader strategy to manage external sector risks. "There is a need for a comprehensive policy on balance of payments," the report said. The report further noted that global

Key Points

- » 'OMCs' under recoveries on sales of petrol and diesel are soaring because of unchanged retail prices'
- » OMCs are 'incurring losses to the tune of Rs 1000 crore per day, which amounts to around Rs 3.6 lakh crore a year'
- » 'The Rs 3/litre hike in fuel prices is expected to provide relief of around Rs 52,700 crore to OMCs, covering only around 15% of their estimated FY27 losses'

crude oil markets remain under pressure amid disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz due to the ongoing West Asia conflict. "As per the latest IEA report, crude will continue to remain under pressure owing to the depleting inventories," the report said.

The report added that shipments through the Strait of Hormuz have declined sharply in recent months, impacting both crude oil and LNG flows.

On inflation, SBI Research said the fuel price hike may have an immediate impact of around 15-20 basis points on Consumer Price Index (CPI) inflation during May-June 2026 and revised its FY27 inflation forecast to 4.7 per cent.

AGENCIES

AI becoming infrastructure of intelligence, says TCS Cahirman Chandrasekaran

NEW DELHI: Tata Consultancy Services Chairman Natarajan Chandrasekaran said artificial intelligence is rapidly evolving into the "infrastructure of intelligence" for enterprises worldwide, reshaping investments, supply chains, risk management and customer engagement.

In his letter to shareholders in the company's FY26 Annual Report, Chandrasekaran said TCS has expanded its 'Human+AI' operating model, generating annualised revenue of \$2.3 billion from AI services and \$11.5 billion from new-age services such as cloud, data and cybersecurity.

He said generative & agentic AI are moving beyond pilot projects to large-scale deploy-

ment, prompting TCS to focus on building secure and sovereign AI infrastructure.

The company plans to develop an industry-focused AI operating system to accelerate adoption of agentic AI solutions and set up India's first AI-centric data centre with rack density exceeding 160 KW. Chandrasekaran said India is emerging as a preferred "+1" destination for AI infrastructure amid global constraints on power, compute and geography.

TCS reported a 12.22 per cent rise in Q4 net profit to Rs 13,718 crore, while FY26 PAT grew 1.35 per cent to Rs 49,210 crore. The firm signed deals worth \$12 billion in March quarter. AGENCIES

Intra-BRICS trade holds vast untapped potential despite strong growth: Commerce Secretary

Issues such as promoting more balanced trade, and opening new opportunities in the services sector were also discussed in the meeting

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The intra-BRICS trade has increased multiple times over the last few years but it accounts for only around 5 per cent of the global trade, reflecting huge untapped potential for deeper integration and stronger value-chain linkages, Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal has said.

BRICS is a grouping of 11 developing countries - Brazil, China, Egypt, Ethiopia, India, Indonesia, Iran, Russia, Saudi Arabia, South Africa and the United Arab Emirates.

It acts as a platform for consultation and cooperation on contemporary issues hav-



ing global as well as regional significance, and issues of global political and economic governance.

India has assumed the BRICS Chairship for the fourth time, after 2012, 2016 and 2021.

Addressing the 2nd Meeting of the BRICS Contact Group on Trade and Economic Issues, held in Gandhinagar, Gujarat, on May 14-15, Agrawal said intra-BRICS merchandise trade has risen

13-fold, from \$84 billion in 2003 to \$1.17 trillion in 2024.

However, he said, this "trade still accounts for only around 5 per cent of global trade, indicating significant untapped potential for deeper trade integration, stronger value-chain linkages and enhanced economic cooperation".

Issues such as promoting more balanced trade, and opening new opportunities in the services sector were also discussed in the meeting.

India's exports to BRICS member countries were estimated at \$82 billion in merchandise goods in 2025-26 and \$31.3 billion in services calendar year 2024.

POWERGRID reports standalone PAT of ₹4,553 crore in Q4 FY26

NEW DELHI: Power Grid Corporation of India Limited (POWERGRID) has announced financial results for period ended Q4FY26 and FY26.

For FY26, on Standalone basis, the Company posted Profit After Tax (PAT) and Total Income of Rs 15,921 crore and Rs 46,996 crore respectively. On consolidated basis, PAT and Total Income were at Rs 15,928 crore and Rs 47,684 crore respectively.

For Q4FY26, on standalone basis, company has reported a PAT of Rs 4,553 crore and Total Income of Rs 11,955 crore. On Consolidated basis, the Company has reported PAT of Rs 4,546 crore and Total Income



of Rs 11,971 crore.

The Company has proposed a final dividend of Rs 1.25 per share on a face value of Rs 10/- each (12.50 per cent of the paid-up share capital) in addition to interim dividend of Rs 7.75/- per share paid for FY26 so far. The total dividend for the year thus amounts to Rs 9 per share.

At the end of FY26, the total transmission assets of POWERGRID and its subsidiaries stood at 1,84,960 ckm of transmis-

sion lines, 291 substations and 6,24,016 MVA of transformation capacity. POWERGRID maintained average transmission system availability of 99.84% during FY26.

During the year, the POWERGRID Board accorded approval for the merger/amalgamation of 28 wholly owned subsidiaries into 2 existing subsidiary companies.

This is in addition to the already completed amalgamation of 19 wholly owned subsidiaries into 2 other existing subsidiary companies. The streamlined SPV structure is aimed at enhancing operational efficiency, management oversight and governance. MPOST

MSME OUTREACH PROGRAM



Central Bank of India organised a Mega MSME Outreach Program at CII Northern Region Headquarters Chandigarh to promote MSME banking products & strengthen engagement with entrepreneurs & business stakeholders. The program was led by Regional Head Chandigarh, Ram Kumar Yadav. K D Pandey, Assistant Commissioner (ACHRCS) was Chief Guest. The event saw active participation from industry members & entrepreneurs. The Bank presented various MSME products including Working Capital Finance, Term Loans, GST-based lending, Vendor Finance, Trade Finance, Machinery Loans, Digital Banking solutions & Govt schemes. MPOST

Coal India plans ₹1 trillion capex over next 5 years to boost output

'The investments are aimed at meeting India's rising energy demand and ensuring uninterrupted coal supplies'

NEW DELHI: Coal India Limited is preparing a capital expenditure plan worth nearly Rs 1 trillion over the next five years to boost coal production, modernise operations and strengthen mining infrastructure.

The proposed investment roadmap will focus on new mining projects, railway connectivity, coal evacuation systems, washeries and the deployment of advanced technologies to improve efficiency and sustainability.

The state-run miner is also expected to step up investments in renewable energy projects and mine safety initiatives as part of its long-term growth strategy.

Officials said the investments are aimed at meeting India's rising energy demand and ensuring uninterrupted coal supplies to power plants and industrial users.

Coal India has been under pressure to increase domestic output amid growing electricity consumption and the govern-

ment's push to reduce dependence on imported coal.

The company has also been expanding into diversification areas such as solar energy and critical mineral exploration in line with the country's broader energy transition goals.

Analysts said the large-scale capital expenditure programme could significantly strengthen Coal India's production capacity and logistics infrastructure while creating jobs and supporting economic activity in coal-bearing regions. AGENCIES

AI reshaping venture capital's economics, new models for valuation and liquidity: WEF

The World Economic Forum report warns that traditional SaaS valuation frameworks and liquidity mechanisms are rapidly becoming outdated

NEW DELHI: World Economic Forum has said artificial intelligence is emerging as a transformative force that is fundamentally reshaping how companies are built, financed and scaled, warning that traditional software-as-a-service (SaaS) valuation frameworks and liquidity mechanisms are rapidly becoming outdated.

In a new report, WEF said AI-native firms are reaching \$100 million in annual recurring revenue (ARR) in less than a year, while five companies alone absorbed 20 per cent of

global venture capital funding in 2025.

The report said the industry must redesign capital structures, regulatory systems and talent ecosystems to support a new era of capital-efficient but infrastructure-intensive growth.

According to the report, the venture capital model of the past three decades was built around software sold to human users, limiting the addressable market to the number of people carrying out a task. The SaaS market eventually grew to around \$300 billion annually. AI, however,



changes this equation by automating cognitive work itself — from legal review and coding to medical diagnostics — expanding the market far beyond human-bound workflows.

CLOSER LOOK

- » WEF said AI-native firms are reaching \$100 million in ARR in less than a year, while five firms alone absorbed 20 per cent of global venture capital funding in 2025
- » The SaaS market eventually grew to around \$300 billion annually. AI, however, changes this equation by automating cognitive work itself

WEF noted that AI-native companies are scaling faster and operating more efficiently than any previous generation of technology firms, though sustaining product-market fit has become

more difficult. "When AI can replicate core product functionality in weeks, the competitive advantages that traditional SaaS companies built on unique features and customer lock-in

begin to erode," the report said.

As a result, ARR is becoming a less dependable valuation benchmark, forcing investors to rethink frameworks designed for conventional software businesses.

The report highlighted that capital concentration within AI reflects the scale of the transformation. In 2025, AI accounted for more than 50 per cent of global VC deal value, with nearly 60 per cent of investments directed towards funding rounds exceeding \$100 million. OpenAI, Scale AI, Anthropic,

Project Prometheus and xAI together raised \$84 billion, equivalent to one-fifth of all global VC funding.

At the same time, major technology firms are expected to spend over \$650 billion in capital expenditure in 2026, largely on AI infrastructure, blurring the distinction between venture capital, private equity and corporate financing.

AI is also changing how venture firms function. Large language models are now being used to analyse patents, hiring data and code repositories to

identify investment opportunities, while natural language processing tools can review legal documents in minutes rather than weeks. AI-powered systems are also enabling real-time monitoring of portfolio companies.

The World Economic Forum said AI's expansion into semiconductors, data centres and energy infrastructure requires new financing models, warning that without liquidity and policy reforms, future AI firms could face major capital shortages. AGENCIES

Focus is on women’s safety, education: CM

‘Respect of our daughters most important’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Saturday said that the safety and education of women is a matter of paramount concern for her government.

Gupta was attending a cycle distribution event in the R K Puram area, organised by the local MLA, Anil Sharma, in association with Rotary Club Delhi Imperial.

During the event, 500 bicycles were distributed to girls who had passed classes 10 and 12.

“In my city of Delhi, the safety, education, and respect of our daughters are the most important issues for me. For this, we have started a scheme called the ‘Lakshpati Bitiya Yojana,’” Gupta said.

The chief minister said that as part of the fuel-saving initiatives underway across the country, a cycle per family would be helpful.

“When I became the chief minister, I felt that my biggest responsibility was to work for my sisters and daughters. Roads, flyovers, bridges — all of these are necessary. Education must be improved, and hospitals must be built. These are all part of our responsibilities,” she said.

Gupta said tenders for providing free cycles to female schoolgoers, as announced by her government earlier this year, have been floated, and her government will distribute cycles after the summer vacation. Around 1.30 lakh



Rekha Gupta distributes bicycles to students on Saturday

Delhi govt set to roll out city logistics plan soon: CM

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has prepared a city logistics plan, which will soon be notified to boost industrial investment, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said on Saturday.

Gupta said the national capital has secured a place in the highest “Exemplary” category in the country’s Logistics Ease Across Different States (LEADS) 2025 Index. Under the index, states and union territories are classified into four categories - Exemplary, High Performer, Accelerators, and Growth Seekers - with Exemplary being the highest category. “This achievement is the result of the Delhi government’s continuous efforts to strengthen logistics infrastructure,” she said.

girls enrol in class 9 every year, and the bicycles will help them

throughout their academic journey, she added.

L-G announces drive to revive 101 water bodies

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a significant push towards environmental sustainability and urban water conservation, Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Saturday launched the “Jal Sanchay Abhiyaan” aimed at rejuvenating 101 water bodies across the national capital.

The initiative, undertaken by the Delhi Development Authority (DDA), seeks to restore and conserve Delhi’s traditional lakes, baolis, reservoirs, and ponds to improve groundwater recharge and ecological balance. The launch event was held at District Park in Paschim Vihar in the presence of area MLA Karnail Singh and DDA Vice-Chairman N.



Taranjit Singh Sandhu launches the 'Jal Sanchay Abhiyaan'

Saravana Kumar.

According to officials, DDA currently manages 822 water bodies across Delhi, of which 424 have been identified for restoration. In the first phase of the campaign, 101 water bodies

spread across nearly 155 hectares will undergo immediate rejuvenation work, including desilting, dredging, excavation, and clearing of natural catchment channels before the monsoon season.

Congress protests fuel, milk price hike

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Congress on Saturday staged protests across the national capital against the recent hike in the prices of petrol, diesel, CNG, and milk, with the Delhi Congress chief Devender Yadav riding a bullock cart to a petrol pump in Karol Bagh to symbolically protest against rising inflation and demand an immediate rollback.

The demonstrations were held outside petrol pumps and dairy booths across all 258 Block Congress Committee (BCC) areas in Delhi, a day after the BJP-led Centre increased petrol and diesel prices by Rs 3 per litre.

They raised slogans against inflation and carried placards criticising the Centre over the rising prices of fuel and essential commodities.

Electric vehicles get 50% parking concession under NDMC plan

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a push towards sustainable urban transport and clean mobility, the New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) on Saturday announced a 50% concession in parking charges for electric vehicles across all its notified parking sites from May 18.

The initiative was announced by NDMC Vice-Chairperson Kuljeet Singh Chahal as part of a broader green mobility campaign inspired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s vision of sustainable and eco-friendly transportation.

According to NDMC officials, the concession will apply to all electric vehicles parked at NDMC-operated parking facilities and will remain in force until further orders. Verification



tion of EV status will be carried out through vehicle registration documents.

The civic body also launched a series of eco-friendly transport services aimed at reducing fuel consumption and encouraging public transport usage among employees and residents.

As part of the initiative, EV auto services were introduced between Palika Kendra and nearby Metro stations, including Patel Chowk, Rajiv Chowk

DU teachers hold protest for permanent jobs

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Hundreds of teachers associated with the Academic for Action and Development Delhi Teachers’ Association (AADTA) staged a protest at Delhi University’s North Campus demanding permanent appointments for ad hoc and temporary faculty members working in 12 Delhi government-funded colleges.

Carrying placards and raising slogans, the protesting teachers urged the authorities to implement the Delhi High Court’s “Namita Khare” judgment, which they said supports the regularisation of long-serving ad hoc faculty members.

According to AADTA representatives, a large number of teachers have been serving in these colleges for several years without receiving permanent appointments, despite fulfilling academic and administrative responsibilities equivalent to regular faculty members.

The association claimed that only 301 teaching posts were officially sanctioned in the academic year 2010-11, while nearly 1,000 teachers are currently employed across the 12 colleges. Teachers alleged that the shortage of sanctioned posts has led to prolonged dependence on temporary appointments, resulting in growing job insecurity.

Faculty members also expressed concern over delays in recruitment processes and demanded immediate approval of pending teaching posts. Protesters said the uncertainty surrounding employment has affected both teachers’ professional stability and the quality of higher education.

VAT on aviation fuel cut from 25% to 7% in Delhi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government on Saturday announced a significant reduction in the value-added tax (VAT) on aviation turbine fuel (ATF), cutting it from 25 per cent to 7 per cent, in a move expected to benefit airlines as well as passengers.

The decision was approved at a Cabinet meeting chaired by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, officials said.

According to an official statement, the tax cut aims to reduce operational costs for airlines and improve overall affordability in the aviation sector. Lower fuel costs are also expected to ease pressure on airfares, potentially offering relief to travellers flying to and from the national capital.

The government said the decision comes against the backdrop of global fuel market volatility triggered by ongoing geopolitical tensions in West Asia, which have led to uncertainty in energy supplies and pricing.

Officials added that the rationalisation of VAT on ATF is part of broader efforts to support the aviation sector and strengthen Delhi’s position as a key aviation hub in the country.

Industry stakeholders are expected to assess the impact of the move in the coming weeks, particularly its effect on ticket pricing and airline operations. The Cabinet reiterated its commitment to policies that balance economic stability with consumer welfare while responding to global energy challenges.

Police busts honeytrap extortion racket

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police has busted a ‘sex-tortion’ racket that allegedly honey-trapped victims through video calls before coercing them for money, officials said on Saturday.

The suspected mastermind behind the honey-trap operations, identified as Arman (23), was arrested from Ladamka village in Rajasthan’s Deeg district, they said.

Police said a man lodged a complaint on the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal alleging he was blackmailed after being trapped through an obscene video call. The complainant claimed he received a video call from an unknown number in which a pre-recorded obscene video featuring a woman was being played.

The victim was manipulated into removing his clothes during the interaction, and the culprits allegedly recorded his private moments.

The accused later sent the recorded clip to the complainant and allegedly demanded Rs 1 lakh, threatening to circulate the video on social media platforms if the money was not paid. “The victim initially transferred some amount out of fear, but approached police after repeated extortion demands,” the officer said.

The mastermind behind the operations, was arrested from in Rajasthan

Based on the complaint, an FIR was registered on May 13. During investigation, police analysed the money trail which was traced to Rajasthan’s Mewar region. Subsequently raids based on technical surveillance led to the arrest of Arman.

“Two mobile phones and 11 SIM cards were recovered from his possession. During examination of the devices, police found nearly 150 obscene videos, including around 50 involving different victims,” he said.

Police said one mobile phone was allegedly used to make video calls and chat with victims, while the second device was used to play pre-recorded obscene videos during calls. During interrogation, the accused disclosed that he used fake identities and randomly picked mobile numbers from social media and dating applications to target people. He allegedly lured victims into intimate conversations and later extorted money by threatening to upload their private videos online.

Youth Congress marches to Pradhan’s residence

DEMAND RESIGNATION OVER NEET LEAK ROW

NEW DELHI: The Indian Youth Congress (IYC) on Saturday here protested demanding the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the alleged NEET paper leak and the suicides of four aspirants.

Holding posters, banners and party flags, IYC activists took out a protest march from Teen Murti Circle towards the education minister’s residence before they were stopped by police barricades.

The police detained several members, including IYC national president Uday Bhanu Chib. The protesters alleged that repeated paper leaks had shaken the confidence of students and exposed serious lapses in the country’s examination system.

Addressing the protesters, Chib said, “The NEET paper



Indian Youth Congress members stage a protest against the NTA

leak and the death of four students have shaken the entire nation to its core. With the futures of millions of students at stake, the government’s silence and negligence are completely unacceptable.”

He also targeted the BJP-led Centre over recurring irregularities in the conduct of entrance

exams.

“This Modi government has transformed democracy into a ‘Leak-ocracy.’ Today, the youth of the country are demanding answers regarding the blatant disregard shown towards their hard work and future,” Chib alleged.

He sought responsibility for

the paper leaks and repeated cancellations of exams. “Dharmendra Pradhan continues to cling to his seat while PM Modi maintains silence. How many more deaths must occur before accountability is established?”

The protesters claimed that 89 exam papers had been leaked in the last 12 years and that the paper for NEET alone was leaked four times. “The BJP has created such a corrupt system that children of the wealthy will secure seats and jobs, while students from poor families will suffer,” an IYC worker alleged.

The Congress youth wing also demanded compensation for the affected students and called for a complete overhaul of the National Testing Agency (NTA), alleging that it had failed in its responsibility to conduct exams fairly.

Six arrested in Rs 128 crore fake GST invoicing racket busted by EOW

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police’s Economic Offences Wing (EOW) has busted an alleged GST fraud cartel operating through shell companies and fake invoicing networks, arresting six individuals involved in swindling Rs 128 crore, an official said on Saturday.

The accused allegedly operated fake firms, generating bogus GST invoices, and availing wrongful Input Tax Credit (ITC) without any actual supply of goods or services, EOW in a statement said.

On May 15, EOW teams made several raids at different locations in Delhi-NCR and arrested Raj Kumar Dixit, Amar Kumar, Vibhash Kumar Mitra, Nitin Verma, Mohammad Waseem, and Abid.

A case of GST fraud was registered against a fake firm, M/s

RK Enterprises, at the EOW Police Station on March 24 under various sections of the BNS.

The complainant alleged that his Aadhaar card, PAN card, electricity bill and biometric details were misused on the pretext of providing him employment in the GST Department, the statement read.

During the investigation, the police found that the firm had been created in September 2025 without the victim’s knowledge and was subsequently used for transactions exceeding Rs 128 crore.

“Wrongful ITC amounting to nearly Rs 10 crore was fraudulently availed through the fake entity,” read the statement.

The probe, involving technical surveillance, analysis of GST records, banking transactions, email IDs and other digital evi-

dence, revealed that Dixit and Dilip Kumar, still at large, were the main conspirators behind the racket.

The police said Dixit operated a large-scale fake invoicing syndicate from Daryaganj with his brothers and associates and orchestrated the creation of nearly 250 shell companies using forged and fraudulently obtained documents.

Investigators said the accused used these firms for bogus billing, fake GST transactions, and fraudulent ITC claims while concealing the financial trail through multiple bank accounts, mobile numbers and intermediaries. Amar Kumar and Vibhash Kumar Mitra facilitated the formation of shell firms and bogus GST activities, they said. The police said around 50 shell companies and entities used for routing money and fake GST entries have so far been identified.

Slight rise in heat, gusty spell likely to continue

IMD has forecast that gusty winds will persist for the next few days

NEW DELHI: The national capital saw a slight increase in the maximum temperature on Saturday, amid forecasts that strong gusty winds will continue in the city for the next couple of days.

Safdarjung, which represents the city’s weather, recorded a maximum temperature of 40 degrees Celsius, 0.4 degree above normal and a one-degree rise from the previous day. The minimum temperature was logged at 24.8 degrees Celsius, 1.7 degrees below normal. The minimum temperature was 26.2 degrees Celsius the day before.

Other weather stations also recorded a similar rise in maximum temperature.

Palam recorded a maxi-

In Short

» The minimum temperature was logged at 24.8 degrees Celsius, 1.7 degrees below normal. The minimum temperature was 26.2 degrees Celsius the day before

» The IMD has forecast the maximum temperature to be around 41-43



degrees Celsius on Sunday

mum of 40.7 degrees Celsius, 0.5 degree more than Friday.

The minimum temperature at Palam was 24.6 degrees, 2.5 degrees below the normal.

Lodhi Road and Ridge recorded maximum tempera-

tures of 41.2 degrees and 42.4 degrees Celsius, respectively.

The temperature at Lodhi Road was 1.4 degrees higher than Friday, and the temperature at Ridge was one degree higher than the previous day.

“Mostly clear skies persisted through the day on Saturday, leading to a slight increase in the maximum temperature, as more heat reaches the earth’s surface,” said an IMD official.

According to the IMD forecast, there is a “possibility of thundery development towards afternoon/evening” on Sunday, along with gusty winds of 20-30 kmph, occasionally gusting to 40 kmph.

“Strong surface winds are expected to continue on Monday as well,” the official said.

The IMD has forecast the maximum temperature to be around 41-43 degrees Celsius on Sunday. The minimum is likely to be around 24-26 degrees Celsius.

Meanwhile, the city’s air

quality remained in the moderate category. The 24-hour average air quality index (AQI) was clocked at 176 (moderate) at 4 pm on Saturday, compared to an AQI of 152 (moderate) recorded at the same time on Friday, according to data from the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB).

As per CPCB standards, an AQI of 0-50 is considered ‘good’, 51-100 ‘satisfactory’, 101-200 ‘moderate’, 201-300 ‘poor’, 301-400 ‘very poor’, and 401-500 ‘severe’. The Air Quality Early Warning System (AQEWS) for Delhi has forecast the AQI to remain in the moderate category over the weekend and then subsequently deteriorate to the poor category on Monday.

Gurugram: Two-and-a-half-year-old girl killed in road accident

GURUGRAM: A two-and-a-half-year-old girl died, and five family members were injured when their Scorpio somersaulted on the Delhi-Mumbai Expressway on Saturday after the driver dozed off, police said.

According to police, the incident occurred in the Nuh district area while a family was returning home to Delhi from Mumbai.

“Six family members were in the car. As the car crossed the Ujina cut and reached the Jaisinghpur Chowki area around 7:00 am on Saturday, the driver suddenly dozed off. The driver lost control of the vehicle, and the speeding car overturned several times before falling off the highway,” police said. The accident was so severe that the car was heavily dam-

3 Nigerians held for duping people by posing as girls

NEW DELHI: Gurugram Police has arrested 3 Nigerians for allegedly defrauding people through various means, including by posing as women on social media platforms, officials said on Saturday.

19 mobile phones, one laptop and 18 Indian and international SIM cards were recovered from their possession, they said. According to the police, a man filed a complaint on April 25, last year, alleging that he had been cheated by a girl that he had met on Instagram.

aged, and all the occupants were injured, they said.

Police said Deepika died on the spot.

“Nishant Gupta, his wife Sakshi Agarwal, residents of Janakpuri, Delhi, Yuvan, his

father Prashant Gupta and his wife Avneeti were injured in the accident. After first aid, all the injured were admitted to a private hospital, where they are undergoing treatment,” police said.

IMPLEMENTING ONE OF WORLD'S LARGEST DAM-REHABILITATION PROGRAMMES

Centre modernising 736 dams under Rs 10,211-cr rehabilitation programme

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India is implementing one of the world's largest dam-rehabilitation programmes under the Dam Rehabilitation and Improvement Programme (DRIP), with rehabilitation proposals worth Rs 5,053 crore for 191 dams already approved and major physical-rehabilitation work completed at 43 dams till March 31, 2025, according to the Jal Shakti Ministry.

The ministry said the second and third phases of the DRIP, operationalised in October 2021, together cover 736 dams across 19 states and three central agencies -- the Central Water Commission (CWC), the Bhakra Beas Management Board (BBMB) and the Damodar Valley Corporation (DVC).

Major dams planned for safety improvement under the second and third phases of the project include the Bhakra Dam (Himachal Pradesh), the Ran-

Highlights

- » The ministry said the second and third phases of the DRIP, operationalised in October 2021, together cover 736 dams across 19 states
- » India currently manages one of the largest dam portfolios globally and ranks third in the world with 6,628 specified dams

jit Sagar Dam (Punjab), NTR Sagar (Telangana), the Nagarjuna Sagar Dam (Telangana), the Gandhi Sagar Dam (Madhya Pradesh), the Kadana Dam (Gujarat), the Jirgo Dam (Uttar Pradesh), the Imphal Barrage (Manipur), the Myntdu Leshka Dam (Meghalaya) and the Silabati Barrage (West Bengal), among others.

The total project outlay for DRIP-II and III is Rs 10,211 crore -- Rs 5,107 crore for Phase-II and Rs 5,104 crore for Phase-III. Of this, Rs 7,000 crore are being provided as external loan assistance, while Rs 3,211 crore are being borne by the partici-

pating states and central agencies. The Phase-II scheme is co-financed by the World Bank and the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB).

"Phase II and III together will last for 10 years, each phase continuing for six years with two years overlap," the ministry said.

It added that DRIP-II and III are structured around four major components -- rehabilitation of dams and associated structures, institutional strengthening, revenue-generation measures to support sustainable operation and maintenance, and project management for effective implementation.

India currently manages one of the largest dam portfolios globally and ranks third in the world with 6,628 specified dams, of which 6,545 are operational and 83 are under construction. The gross water-storage capacity of these dams is about 330 billion cubic metres and they are critical for ensuring national food, energy and water security.

The ministry said more than 26 per cent of these dams, or 1,681 structures, are over 50 years old, including 291 that are more than 100 years old, while another 42 per cent fall in the 25-50 years age bracket.

"Ageing infrastructure, sedimentation, changing hydrological patterns and increasing climate variability have highlighted the need for systematic rehabilitation and safety management," it said. According to an analysis of 439 reservoirs by the CWC, reservoirs in India have suffered an average 19 per cent loss of gross storage capac-

ity, with the average annual loss estimated at 0.74 per cent, equivalent to about 1.81 MCM per reservoir per year.

Describing the DRIP as "among the largest dam rehabilitation programmes globally", the ministry said the initiative reflects India's shift towards a "systematic and risk-based approach to dam safety management".

The programme is being implemented in three phases to improve the safety and operational performance of the existing dams through structural repairs, modernisation of spillways and gates, and the installation of advanced monitoring systems.

DRIP Phase-I was launched in April 2012 with support from the World Bank and continued till 2021. The programme covered 223 dams across seven states -- Jharkhand, Karnataka, Kerala, Madhya Pradesh, Odisha, Tamil Nadu and Uttarakhand.

Tree plantation in Gandhinagar led to decline of 2-3 degrees in temp: Shah

OUR CORRESPONDENT

AHMEDABAD: Union Home minister Amit Shah on Saturday said that 1.5 crore saplings were planted in his Gandhinagar Lok Sabha constituency over the past three years, and it led to a decrease of 2 to 3 degrees Celsius in the average temperature of the area.

Speaking at a review meeting with officials, he called for a large-scale plantation drive in 2026-27 to make Gandhinagar a green Lok Sabha constituency.

During his Gujarat visit, Shah held several meetings, including one with the newly-elected Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation councillors from Ghatlodiya, Vejalpur, Naranpura and Sabarmati assembly segments that fall under the Gandhinagar Lok Sabha constituency.

He congratulated the councillors on their victory and had a detailed discussion regarding organisational matters, public service and regional development, the senior BJP leader said in a post on X.

"I am confident that all the



Union Home minister Amit Shah chairs a review meeting of the 'Akhand Anand and Sastu Sahitya Mudranalay Trust', in Ahmedabad

councillors elected by the public will live up to the expectations of the public and work with dedication, dialogue, and service spirit, playing active role in the development of the area," he wrote.

He also reviewed the progress of development works of the Gujarat Urban Development Company (GUDC) and Mansa Municipality within his constituency, and attended a meeting of the Sastu Sahitya Mudranalay Trust.

"Tree plantation and restoration of ponds have become a new hallmark of the Gandhinagar Lok Sabha constituency. Over the past three years, 1.5

crore trees have been planted in the region. As a result of these sustained efforts, a decline of 2-3 degrees has been recorded in the average temperature of the Lok Sabha constituency," he tweeted.

"In this direction, today, a review meeting was held on the ongoing tree plantation work under the 'Green Lok Sabha - Gandhinagar Lok Sabha' resolution...a detailed discussion was also held on the interlinking of lakes in Gandhinagar Lok Sabha area," Shah said.

He also reviewed the functioning of public hospitals in the constituency and modernisation of the Sarkhej-Gandhinagar Highway.

Odisha boy dies, four hospitalised in suspected food poisoning case

KENDRAPARA: A 12-year-old boy died on Saturday morning while four of his family members were undergoing treatment with complaints of nausea and breathing difficulties after having curries and watermelon the night before in Odisha's Kendrapara district, police said.

The chief district medical officer (CDMO), Sachidananda Mishra, said the curries the family had for dinner might

have been stale.

He said all five were admitted to the community health centre at Pattamundai on Saturday morning with complaints of vomiting, loose motion and breathing difficulties, which they claimed started after having food the previous night.

As their condition worsened, they were shifted to the district headquarters hospital in Kendrapara.

AGENCIES

CBSE makes three-language study compulsory in Class 9 from July 1

Continued from Page 1

All assessments for R3 will be conducted internally by schools, with performance still recorded on CBSE certificates. Critically, no student will be blocked from sitting the Class 10 board examinations on account of R3.

"To keep the focus on learning and reduce any undue pressure on students, no board examination shall be conducted for R3 at the Class X level. All assessments for R3 shall be entirely school-based and internal," the notification said, adding that the performance "will

be duly reflected in the CBSE certificate".

The three-language formula is not entirely new territory for CBSE. Earlier curriculum reports had outlined a phased rollout starting from Class 6, extending to Class 10 by 2030-31. The May 15 circular does not alter that broader framework but formalises the timeline and enforcement specifically for Classes 9 and 10, bringing them into the fold from this July.

Because the academic year opened in April, the board has opted for a transitional approach rather than an immediate hard shift. "CBSE has decided to adopt

a transitional approach to align its Scheme of Studies with the NCERT syllabus," the circular noted, with the board making clear that no student will be disadvantaged during this adjustment phase.

On the ground, one of the sharpest challenges will be teacher availability. Recognising that many schools may not have qualified native Indian language teachers on staff, CBSE has opened several interim pathways. Schools can share faculty across institutions through Sahodaya school clusters; adopt virtual or hybrid teaching arrangements, bringing back retired language

teachers; or assign existing teachers from other subjects who have functional proficiency in the relevant language.

Schools must update their R3 language offerings for classes 6 to 9 on the OASIS portal by June 30, 2026, giving the board a window to map resources before the July deadline.

Textbooks present another practical gap that CBSE has moved to address. Until dedicated R3 textbooks are developed, Class 9 students will use Class 6-level textbooks for the third language.

The board noted approximately 75 to 80 per cent overlap

in core language competencies between the middle and secondary stages, covering oral communication, reading comprehension, written expression and grammatical awareness, making the interim arrangement workable.

"Class VI R3 textbooks in 19 scheduled languages will be made available to schools before July 1. For the remaining native Indian languages, available SCERT and state-level resources may be used, as per past practice," the circular stated. Schools are also expected to supplement learning with local and regional literature including poems,

short stories and non-fiction texts. Detailed teaching guidelines from CBSE are expected by June 15.

The policy also builds in exemptions for those who need them.

Children with special needs may be exempted from studying a second or third language under the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act 2016, while foreign students returning to India can apply for case-by-case exemptions from the two-Indian-language requirement. Schools operating outside India will be covered under separate flexible provisions.

From Page 1 PM warns

Chandrayaan-3 mission, which in 2023 landed on a part of the Moon no other mission had reached before, and said India is working on one of the world's most advanced fast breeder nuclear reactors. He also referenced India's hosting of the G20 New Delhi Summit and what he described as the world's largest AI Summit.

"These were not merely one-time events; this has now become the character and confidence of today's India," he said.

Modi told the diaspora that India's goals now include hosting the Olympics, building itself into a global manufacturing hub, leading in green energy, and acting as a growth engine for the world economy. He asked the Indian community in the Netherlands and others he called "friends of India" to strengthen their ties with the country. "This will strengthen India's capabilities, and it will also bring greater returns on your investments, and this is Modi's guarantee," he said.

On India-Netherlands ties, he said the two countries are working together on green hydrogen, water security, and energy security. He also pointed to the recently signed trade agreement between India and the European Union as a foundation for stronger bilateral trade. He called the Netherlands a "natural gateway" for Indian businesses entering Europe and said the diaspora could serve as a bridge in that process.

Modi drew a comparison between the Netherlands' tulip and India's lotus, saying both flowers show that roots in different conditions can still produce strength and beauty. He used the image to describe the partnership between the two countries.

He also acknowledged the Indian community's role in Dutch cricket, naming players Teja Nidamanuru, Vikramjit Singh, and Aryan Dutt as examples of that contribution.

On the domestic front, Modi pointed to voter turnout figures from recent assembly elections in Assam, West Bengal, Kerala, Tamil Nadu, and Puducherry, where participation ranged from 80 to 90 per cent. He said women's participation had gone up across states. "When people's dreams are fulfilled, their faith in democracy grows stronger as well," he said.

He took a light jab at opposition parties by asking the crowd whether Jhalmuri, a street snack from eastern India, had reached the Netherlands. The reference was to a moment during campaigning in West Bengal, where Modi was seen eating the snack at a local shop. His party went on to win the state elections.

Modi also noted the personal significance of the day. May 16 marks 12 years since his party won the general elections in India. "A stable and absolute majority government was set to be formed in India after decades," he said. He reflected on his own career, citing 13 years as chief minister, 12 years as prime minister, and 25 years in public life.

Modi arrived in the Netherlands on Friday after a stop in the UAE. His tour continues to Sweden, Norway, and Italy.

Bandi Sanjay

result of a honey-trap and extortion attempt. In a counter-complaint he filed in Karimnagar, he alleged that the girl and her parents had pressured him to marry her, and when he refused, demanded money and threatened to lodge false complaints. He claimed he paid Rs 50,000 to the girl's father out of fear, after which the family allegedly raised their demand to Rs 5 crore. He also claimed they threatened that the girl's mother would take her own life if he did not pay. Police filed an FIR based on his complaint as well.

The Telangana High Court heard Bhageerath's anticipatory bail petition in a session that lasted until nearly midnight on Friday. Justice T Madhavi Devi said the court was not inclined to grant any interim relief at that stage. Senior advocate Pappu Nageshwar Rao, appearing for the survivor, alleged in court that the minister was using his influence to affect the investigation and that attempts had been made through a person identified as Sangappa to settle the matter. He also alleged that four other girls had faced harassment and would come forward later.

Bhageerath's counsel argued that a close reading of the complaint did not disclose allegations amounting to penetrative sexual assault and that the relevant section was added later with what he called malicious intent. The state government's public prosecutor countered that detailed evidence had been collected and that the gravity of the accusations had become clear only after the survi-

vor's statement was recorded.

Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy had earlier directed that a woman officer oversee the probe, and IPS officer Ritiraj was appointed to monitor the investigation.

BRS leader K Kavitha wrote to Prime Minister Narendra Modi demanding the minister's removal from the Union Cabinet to ensure a free and fair investigation.

Speaking at a public event in Karimnagar before the arrest, Sanjay Kumar said, "If my son has done anything wrong, he will definitely face punishment. I do not want separate treatment for my son."

NEET paper

and their correct answers to a select group of students, who wrote them down by hand. When the NEET-UG paper was held on May 3, most of those questions appeared in it.

Mandhare's arrest follows that of Professor Prahlad Vithalrao Kulkarni on Friday. Kulkarni, a chemistry lecturer from Latur who had spent years serving on panels that set the NEET question paper, is regarded by the CBI as the alleged kingpin of the operation. He, too, is said to have run special coaching sessions at his Pune residence during the last week of April, dictating questions, answer choices and correct responses to students mobilised through Waghmare. "The questions so dictated were handwritten by students in their notebooks and have exactly tallied with the actual question paper of NEET-UG 2026 Examination held on May 3," the agency said in a statement. Both Kulkarni and Mandhare are alleged to have collected lakhs of rupees in fees from students who attended these sessions.

Later in the day, Special CBI Judge Ajay Gupta granted the agency ten days of custodial interrogation for Kulkarni and Waghmare after Special Public Prosecutor Neetu Gupta sought a 14-day remand, arguing that a larger conspiracy was involved and that both accused needed to be taken to different parts of the country as the probe was still at an early stage. The court noted that Waghmare had conspired with a public servant associated with the NTA and others to obtain the question paper and answers, subsequently distributing them to several people, including co-accused Dhananjay Lokhande, for monetary gain. She is also alleged to have destroyed the leaked paper after the exami-

nation was conducted. The court rejected arguments from Kulkarni's counsel, who contended that no NTA official had been arrested and that paper-setters worked in isolation without knowing which of their questions would make it into the final paper. Agreeing with the CBI, the judge listed several reasons for granting custody: the need to unearth the full conspiracy, recover digital evidence and trace the financial trail, and prevent other members of the network from destroying further material.

The CBI's remand papers revealed that Waghmare knew Kulkarni through Mandhare and was in contact with co-accused Lokhande, who had already been sent to CBI custody for six days on Friday. Earlier on Thursday, five others, Shubham Khairnar from Nashik, Mangilal Biwal, Vikas Biwal and Dinesh Biwal from Jaipur, and Yash Yadav from Gurugram, were remanded to CBI custody until May 20.

The NEET-UG is the gateway examination for admission to undergraduate medical courses across the country. The NTA said it first received information about possible malpractice on the evening of May 7, four days after the test was held, and passed it to central agencies the following morning for verification and action. The exam was cancelled on Tuesday. The government has since asked the CBI to carry out a comprehensive inquiry into the irregularities, and the agency has registered an FIR and formed multiple teams to pursue the investigation.

Centre to SC

According to the affidavit, the independence of the Election Commission does not rest on who sits on its appointment committee. "Substantive independence of the Election Commission arises from its constitutional status, security of tenure, removal safeguards and statutory protections of its functions and emoluments," the government said, adding that the 2023 Act preserves these features while bringing procedural transparency to the appointments.

The Centre also pointed to the Supreme Court's own March 2, 2023 verdict in the Anoop Baranwal case. In that judgment, the court had said the CEC and election commissioners should be appointed on the advice of a committee including the Prime Minister, the Leader of Opposition and the Chief Justice of India. However, the court had also held

that this arrangement would apply only until Parliament enacted a law on the subject.

"This court held that the said norm laid down by it via the said judgment will continue to hold good only till a law is made by Parliament on this behalf," the government's affidavit noted. It said the court's interim directive "did not have the status of a declaration of law" and cannot be elevated to positive legislation by the courts.

On the petitioners' allegation that the government acted with hidden motive in passing the law, the Centre said no law enacted by a competent legislature can be struck down on the ground of ulterior motive. It also rejected the claim that a selection committee without a judicial member would inevitably be biased, saying such an argument is "wholly incorrect".

The affidavit stated that the independence of the chief election commissioner or an election commissioner depends more on the individual's conduct and professional qualities than on the manner of selection. It added that no allegation has been raised so far regarding the credentials or suitability of any election commissioner appointed under the new law. The government also addressed the petitioners' allegation that Parliament had deliberately suspended several members while passing the Bill. It said the conduct of parliamentary proceedings rests with the Speaker of the Lok Sabha or the Chairperson of the Rajya Sabha and "cannot be a subject matter of question before any forum".

The Supreme Court is currently hearing arguments on the petitions challenging the 2023 Act.

Govt imposes

Over the full 2025-26 fiscal year, inbound shipments surged nearly 150 per cent to USD 12 billion, with volumes climbing 42 per cent to 7,334.96 tonnes. The metal currently trades at around Rs 2.53 lakh per kilogram.

The policy tightening comes against the backdrop of a declining foreign exchange reserve. The country's forex reserves slipped to USD 690 billion for the week ended May 1, down from a record USD 728.49 billion in late February, before the outbreak of the West Asia conflict placed fresh pressure on the rupee through costlier imports. Reserve Bank of India data shows foreign currency assets fell to USD 551.8 billion, while gold reserves stood

at USD 115 billion. Silver's wide industrial application across solar panels, electrical switches, medical equipment and chemical catalysts makes its price sensitivity a concern for manufacturers even as the government prioritises currency stability.

Asian Games

Agnimitra Paul, has assured that law will take its course and persons found guilty will be punished accordingly.

Trinamool Congress national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee has vehemently condemned the incident, stating that this cannot be allowed to become the "new normal".

According to allegations raised by Barman, at around 9 pm on Friday, miscreants set fire to a room adjacent to her residence in Ghosh Para, Kaliyaganj. The room, which is part of the family's old house, is currently occupied by her younger brother. Swapna also alleged that some youths have also threatened to gang rape her.

After receiving information, personnel from the Jalpaiguri Kotwali Police Station, along with the fire brigade, rushed to the spot and brought the blaze under control.

Following the incident, Swapna shared a post on social media, writing: "Had I known this would happen, I truly would not have come into politics. Today, they even set my house on fire." Her statement quickly went viral and sparked reactions from political circles. On Saturday, Swapna formally submitted a complaint at the police station seeking security for herself and her family. Speaking after the incident, she said: "I am an athlete, and I never imagined politics could be this cruel. Today, I am living with insecurity. I have been threatened on the streets. I joined politics to serve people. If such situations arise after losing an election, then will any other woman come forward in future? I never thought politics would be like this, but I will continue my struggle."

Meanwhile, several neighbours and local residents staged a protest outside the Jalpaiguri Kotwali Police Station on Saturday and also lodged a counter-complaint. They alleged that Swapna Barman and her brothers often threatened people in the locality. According to them, Friday night's incident was related to a family dispute involving her brothers, and attempts were being made to give it a political colour.

Amarnath K, Superintendent of Police, Jalpaiguri said: "No one was staying in Swapna Barman's old tin-roofed house. A stockpile of firewood kept beside the house had caught fire and was later extinguished by the fire brigade. Some partially burnt documents were recovered from the spot. We have received two complaints regarding the incident, and an investigation has been started."

Reacting to the allegations, Agnimitra Paul said strict action should be taken against anyone found guilty of setting fire to Swapna's house. She added that harassment or violence in the name of politics would not be tolerated.

Abhishek Banerjee wrote on social media: "The BJP government must answer. This cannot become the new normal. If supporting the Trinamool Congress now means risking your safety, your family and even your home, where are we headed as a nation? If this is how an athlete who brought glory to India is treated for her political choices, the state of democracy should worry every Indian."

India rejects

has firmly rejected all prior pronouncements of the illegally constituted CoA," he said, adding that any proceeding, award, or decision issued by the body is "null and void".

Jaiswal also confirmed that India's decision to place the Indus Waters Treaty in "abeyance" remains in effect. That step was taken the day after the April 22, 2025 Pahalgaon terror attack, when India announced a series of punitive measures against Pakistan, suspending the six-decade-old treaty among them.

India has consistently maintained that the Court of Arbitration was improperly constituted, a position it has held throughout the proceedings. Saturday's rejection follows that same stand, with New Delhi making clear it does not intend to recognise any outcome from the tribunal.

CJI clarifies

The Chief Justice added that Indian youth hold him in high regard, and that he sees them as the pillars of a developed India, describing the media characterisation of his remarks as a complete distortion of what was said in court.

DISCUSSES COOPERATION IN TECHNOLOGY, INNOVATION

Modi meets Dutch royals in Netherlands

THE HAGUE: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday met King of the Netherlands Willem-Alexander and Queen Maxima at the Royal Palace and discussed close cooperation in digital technology, innovation, fintech and blue economy.

Modi arrived in the Netherlands on Friday - after a brief stopover in the UAE - on the second leg of his five-nation tour that also includes Sweden, Norway and Italy.

"Met His Majesty King Willem-Alexander and Her Majesty Queen Maxima at the Royal Palace. It was wonderful exchanging perspectives on boosting India-Netherlands friendship across key sectors like technology, innovation, sustainable growth, commerce and water resources," PM Modi posted on X after the meeting.

Modi said that India and the Netherlands are "connected by shared interests and a shared belief in building a future-ready planet."

"They discussed the grow-



Prime Minister Narendra Modi interacts with Netherlands King Willem-Alexander and Queen Maxima during a meeting, in Amsterdam

ing partnership between India and the Netherlands," the Ministry of External Affairs spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal posted on X.

"Both sides noted the close cooperation in the areas of sustainability, climate action, digital technology, innovation, fintech and blue economy," he added.

The two sides also expressed commitment towards further strengthening India-Nether-

lands relations.

Earlier in the day, Modi addressed a gathering of the Indian diaspora in The Hague where he called India a "land of opportunities" undergoing an "unprecedented transformation".

The PM's visit to the European nation from May 15 to 17 is his second trip to the country after his 2017 visit and comes at what officials described as an "important juncture" in India-

Netherlands hands back Chola dynasty copper plates to India

THE HAGUE: The Netherlands on Saturday handed back 11th-century Chola dynasty copper plates to India, in an event attended by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, signifying the strengthening of ties between the two countries.

PM Modi, who arrived in the Netherlands on Friday

after a brief stopover in the UAE on the second leg of his five-nation tour, described the occasion as "a joyous moment for every Indian".

India has been pursuing the return of the Anaimangalam Copper Plates, known in the Netherlands as the Leiden Plates, since 2012.

Netherlands ties.

India and the Netherlands have significantly expanded cooperation in recent years beyond traditional sectors such as trade, investment and the priority areas of water, agriculture and health.

The partnership has grown in strategic sectors, including technology, innovation, defence, security, semiconductors, renewable energy, education and the maritime domain, the MEA said.

The Netherlands is one of India's largest trade destinations in Europe, with bilateral trade valued at USD 27.8 billion in 2024-25. It is also India's fourth-largest investor, with cumulative foreign direct investment amounting to USD 55.6 billion, officials said.

People-to-people ties remain a key pillar of the bilateral relationship.

Later on Saturday, Modi is scheduled to meet his Dutch counterpart Rob Jetten.

PUNJAB SIR

Won't allow even single genuine vote to be deleted: CM

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Amid growing concerns over manipulation of electoral rolls in several states, Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Saturday declared that the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) would not allow even a single genuine vote to be deleted in Punjab under the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) process.

Warning against any attempt to engineer "fake votes" in favour of a particular political party, CM Mann asserted that AAP leaders and karyakartas would remain stationed alongside Booth Level Officers (BLOs) at every polling booth across Punjab to monitor the exercise and prevent any irregularity.

Referring to complaints from other states regarding



deletion of lakhs of genuine votes and irregularities in the verification process, the Chief Minister said the people of Punjab would not permit such practices in the state and urged the Election Commission (EC) to carry out the entire SIR exercise with complete honesty, transparency and impartiality while ensuring that public objections are resolved without delay.

Interacting with the media, Mann said, "The Special Intensive Revision of voter lists must be conducted with complete transparency, honesty, fairness and accountability so that every genuine voter can exercise their democratic right without fear or obstruction. Representatives of all political parties will remain actively involved throughout the process to ensure that no irregu-

larities take place anywhere in Punjab."

Meanwhile, CM Mann on Saturday flagged off the largest-ever batch of 72 government school teachers for advanced training in Finland, asserting that the Punjab government's investment in teacher training, modern classrooms and academic reforms has transformed Punjab into the country's leading state in education.

Drawing a sharp contrast with the decades-long neglect of public education by previous governments, CM Mann said Punjab's govt schools are now outperforming private schools in board examination results, while lakhs of parents are voluntarily participating in Parent-Teacher Meetings started for the first time by the present government.

'Amrit Kaal' proving to be 'Mrit Kaal' for students: Congress over NEET row

Sack Dharmendra Pradhan: Rahul to PM

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Amid the NEET cancellation row, the Congress on Saturday alleged that under the Modi government, the 'Amrit Kaal' is proving to be "Mrit Kaal (era of death)" for students preparing for recruitment examinations and demanded Education minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation.

The Opposition party claimed that Pradhan doesn't appear to be cut out for the task and said that while Prime Minister Narendra Modi gives great publicity to his annual "Pariksha pe Charcha extravaganza", what is needed is "Pariksha ki Samiksha (review of exams)".

Taking a swipe at Modi, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge said he must hold a "Pariksha leaks pe charcha (discussion on exam leaks)", asserting that mere silence will achieve nothing.

"Under the Modi government, the 'Amrit Kaal' is proving to be 'Mrit Kaal' for students preparing for recruitment examinations," Kharge said in a post in Hindi on X.

"According to reports, several students have committed suicide due to the trauma caused by the NEET paper leak scandal. Ritik Mishra from Lakhimpur Kheri, 20-year-old Anshika Pandey from Delhi, Pradeep Meghwal from Jhunjhunu, Rajasthan, and a student from Bengaluru residing in Goa -- all have taken this tragic, suicidal step," Kharge said.

CLOSER LOOK

- » The Opposition party claimed that Pradhan doesn't appear to be cut out for the task
- » Under the Modi regime, more than 90 examination papers have been leaked, Kharge claimed
- » Rahul Gandhi said the hard work of 22 lakh NEET aspirants has gone to waste

"Some had harboured this dream since childhood; others staked everything on fulfilling their families' expectations, spending years in preparation. Yet, the Modi government's corrupt and incompetent system has trampled upon their dreams," he said.

Under the Modi regime, more than 90 examination papers have been leaked, he claimed, adding that over 90 million students and their families have been adversely affected.

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Saturday also demanded that Prime Minister Narendra Modi should immediately sack Education minister Dharmendra Pradhan or take personal accountability, and alleged that the "BJP-RSS nexus" has destroyed India's education system.

The Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha said the hard work of 22 lakh NEET aspirants has gone to waste.

UP: Industries face pressure amid rising costs, govt proposes 2-day WFH

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: Industries across Uttar Pradesh are facing mounting pressure due to rising production costs and disruption in gas supply, prompting the state govt to consider emergency measures to prevent large-scale impact on employment and industrial output.

The issue was discussed in a high-level meeting of the labour department, where officials reviewed the growing difficulties being faced by manufacturing units and industrial establishments dependent on gas-based operations.

To reduce energy consumption and provide relief to industrial units, the government has decided to introduce a work from home system for two days every week in selected sectors and offices. Officials said the move is aimed at lowering power and fuel consumption while ensuring continuity of operations.

Temple-mosque litigation in India: Krishna Janmabhoomi, Kashi Vishwanath and others

There are over 6 petitions challenging various provisions of 1991 law pending adjudication in SC

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Bhojshala-Kamal Maula Mosque disputed site in Dhar district, which the Madhya Pradesh High Court on Friday ruled is a temple dedicated to Goddess Saraswati, is among the prominent legal cases in the country regarding the religious character of places of worship.

The high court quashed a decades-old order of the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) that only allowed the Muslim community to offer Friday prayers at the site while restricting the right of Hindus to worship within the complex.

Apart from the Ayodhya title dispute, in which the Supreme Court order in 2019 led to the building of a Ram temple at the site, here are some of the other similar significant cases.

In most of these, the Places of Worship (Special Provisions) Act, 1991, which mandates maintaining the religious character of a place as it existed on August 15, 1947, has been cited during litigation.



Pigeons fly over the 'Krishna Janmasthan' Temple and Shahi Idgah Mosque, in Mathura, Wednesday

There are over six petitions challenging various provisions of the 1991 law pending adjudication in the top court.

Krishna Janmabhoomi-Shahi Idgah Mosque, Mathura, Uttar Pradesh

The case pertains to a 13.37-acre complex in Mathura that included the Krishna Janmabhoomi temple complex, believed to be Lord Krishna's birthplace, and the Shahi Idgah mosque.

While the Hindu commu-

nity has claimed that the Shahi Idgah mosque was built over an earlier temple at the birthplace of the deity during Mughal emperor Aurangzeb's reign in the 17th century, the Muslim side has invoked the Places of Worship Act, 1991.

Kashi Vishwanath temple-Gyanvapi Mosque, Varanasi, Uttar Pradesh

The dispute surrounding two religious structures, situated adjacent to each other in the

holy city of Varanasi, is among the three most high-profile cases along with Ayodhya and Mathura. The Hindu side has claimed that the original Kashi Vishwanath temple was demolished during Aurangzeb's reign and the Gyanvapi Mosque was built over it.

The Muslim side has asserted that the dispute is barred by the Places of Worship Act, as they have been offering prayers at the mosque continuously for centuries.

Shahi Jama Masjid, Sambhal, Uttar Pradesh

In 2024, Sambhal district became the centre of a controversy after a local court ordered a survey of the Shahi Jama Masjid on a suit by a Hindu devotee alleging that it was built at the site of an ancient Hindu temple.

The Hindu side has claimed that the Shahi Jama Masjid was built during Mughal emperor Babur's reign in 1526 after destroying the Harihar temple devoted to Lord Vishnu's final avatar Kalki.

Quwwat-ul-Islam Mosque, Delhi

Hindu and Jain devotees filed a suit in a civil court in Delhi in 2021 for the restoration of Hindu and Jain deities inside the Qutub Minar complex, claiming that 27 temples were partly demolished by Qutubuddin Aibak, a general in the army of Mohamad Gauri, and the Quwwat-ul-Islam Mosque was raised inside the complex by reusing the material.

The ASI said the mosque was inside the Qutub complex, a protected monument, and no religious worship is currently permitted there.

Idgah Maidan, Hubballi (Karnataka)

In 2022, the local authorities allowed Ganesh Chaturthi celebrations at Hubballi Idgah Maidan in Karnataka, which faced Opposition from Anjuman-e-Islam.

The Karnataka High Court upheld the order of the Dharwad municipal commissioner, holding that the property belonged to the Dharwad municipality and Anjuman-e-Islam was only a leaseholder for a period of 999 years at a fee of Re 1 per year.

TAMIL NADU MINISTERS' PORTFOLIOS

CM Vijay to helm general admin, police, women, youth welfare

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHENNAI: In his maiden government, Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay will handle key portfolios including police, general administration and welfare of women, youth and children, while veteran leader K A Sengottaiyan has been designated as the Finance Minister, the Lok Bhavan said on Saturday.

By keeping Home for himself, Vijay continues the trend of Chief Ministers in TN retaining the important portfolio with themselves.

The portfolios for all the 10 ministers, including Vijay, were approved by Governor Rajendra Viswanath Arlekar as per the recommendation of the chief minister, a Tamil Nadu Lok Bhavan press release said.

The portfolio allocations came a week after the council of ministers led by Vijay was sworn in on May 10.

However, a string of subjects/portfolios such as Hindu



TN Governor Rajendra Arlekar greets newly-elected state Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay during the latter's swearing-in ceremony, in Chennai

Religious and Charitable Endowments, Excise and Prohibition, Transport, Revenue, Social Welfare, Labour welfare, Housing, Tourism, Information Technology, Handlooms and Textiles, Commercial Taxes, Backward Classes Welfare, Environment, Minorities Welfare and Dairy are yet to be allotted and 24 more ministers can be appointed as the strength of the TN Assembly is 234.

According to the Lok Bhavan, Vijay will handle public, general administration,

IAS, IPS, IFS, District Revenue Officers, police, Special Programme Implementation, women and youth welfare, welfare of children, aged, differently abled persons, municipal administration and urban and water supply.

But for the 78-year old Sengottaiyan, a veteran politician who had been with the AIADMK for about 50 years before joining the TVK, all others have become ministers for the first time.

Sengottaiyan, as a minister in the past, had held various portfolios including school education, agriculture, information technology, transport and forest. He won as an MLA for the 10th time in 2026 Assembly polls.

N Anand was designated minister for rural development and water resources and his subjects include rural development, panchayats and panchayat union, poverty alleviation programme, and irrigation.

CM Sai conducts surprise visit to Kosla village



Vishnu Deo Sai

RAIPUR: Under the ongoing 'Sushasan Tihar' campaign, Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai conducted a surprise visit to Kosla village in Pamgarh development block of Janjgir-Champa district on May 16.

The Chief Minister's "simple and citizen-centric" approach was evident when he joined villagers at a traditional chaupal under the shade of a peepal tree and sat on a cot among them without formalities. The moment became memorable for villagers and reflected the government's commitment towards "direct dialogue and responsive governance".

During the chaupal, Chief Minister Sai held discussions with villagers, women and farmers regarding the implementation of various welfare schemes of the state govern-

ment. He listened carefully to public grievances and instructed officials on the spot to ensure quick resolution of issues.

The Chief Minister stated that the objective of Sushasan Tihar is to establish "stronger coordination between the government and citizens" and to ensure that the benefits of welfare schemes reach the last person in society.

MPOST

Chief Minister Saini launches Prashikshan Maha Abhiyan-2026

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Saturday inaugurated the two-day Prashikshan Maha Abhiyan-2026 in Yamunanagar. Earlier, the Chief Minister offered prayers at Saraswati Udgam Sthal Shri Adi Badri Narayan Temple and prayed for the progress and prosperity of the state.

He also inaugurated an exhibition showcasing the development works of Haryana.

The Chief Minister said that the state government has

launched the Deendayal Lado Lakshmi Yojana to provide economic and social security to women and girls.

Under the scheme, financial assistance of Rs 2,100 is being provided. So far, Rs 1,415 crore has been given to around 9.76 lakh women beneficiaries. Poor women are also being provided LPG cylinders at Rs 500 every month to help manage household expenses. Under this scheme, Rs 243 crore has been transferred to the bank accounts of around 14.38 lakh eligible women in the state.

He said that farmers' welfare is at the centre of the gov-

ernment's policies. All 24 crops are being purchased at the Minimum Support Price (MSP). So far, Rs 1,80,000 crore has been transferred into the accounts of 12 lakh farmers for crop procurement. During the last 11 years, farmers have been given compensation worth Rs 16,160 crore under compensation schemes and the Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana for crop losses.

Under the Pradhan Mantri Kisan Samman Nidhi Yojana, around 20.18 lakh farmers have received Rs 7,562 crore in 22 instalments directly into their bank accounts.

'India's quantum and AI sovereignty will drive next-generation growth'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Quantum and Artificial Intelligence sovereignty, along with indigenous ecosystems, will define India's next-generation growth, Union Minister of State for Science and Technology Jitendra Singh said on Saturday, asserting that the country's future in deep-tech sectors will hinge on its ability to adopt "a trusted integrated approach".

Addressing a programme organised by the Technology Development Board (TDB) at the Dr Ambedkar International Centre, the Minister released the first electronic fund disbursement of Rs 50 crore to Bengaluru-based Eystem Research Private Limited under the Research, Development and Innovation (RDI) Fund Scheme. Agreements for five high-impact projects were also signed during the event.

The five recipients span strategic sectors: e-TRNL Energy for advanced lithium-ion battery cells, Dhruva Space for a 500-kg-class modular satellite platform, Eystem Research for indigenous

cell therapies, Noccarc Robotics for a portable ICU-grade life support system, and Endure Air Systems for an unmanned helicopter platform.

Singh said India is now among a selected group of countries investing in quantum communication, computing, sensing and materials under the National Quantum Mission, noting that the country had achieved nearly half of its 2,000 km quantum-secure communication target in under four years against an original eight-year timeline.

He warned that emerging quantum capabilities posed risks to existing cryptographic systems in banking, governance and telecom, making post-quantum cryptography "critical for long-term national security".

Meanwhile, Union minister Jitendra Singh also lauded the Sree Chitra Tirunal Institute for Medical Sciences and Technology (SCTIMST), Thiruvananthapuram, for its, cost-effective indigenous medical devices, as he virtually addressed the institute's 42nd annual convocation in the presence of Union Health Secretary Punya Salila Srivastava.

Israel kills Hamas military wing leader, an architect of Oct 7 attacks

Israel’s army described Izz al-Din al-Haddad as one of senior Hamas military commanders who directed planning, execution of Oct 7 attacks

TEL AVIV: An Israeli airstrike in Gaza killed the leader of Hamas’ military wing who was one of the last surviving architects of the attacks that triggered the war in late 2023, the Israeli military said Saturday. Hamas confirmed the death.

Izz al-Din al-Haddad was killed on Friday, Israel’s army said, describing him as one of the senior Hamas military commanders who directed the planning and execution of the Hamas-led attacks on October 7, 2023, which killed around 1,200 people in southern Israel and saw more than 250 taken hostage.

A Hamas spokesperson, Hazem Qassem, confirmed the killing on social media. The ceasefire between Israel and Hamas remains fragile, and the top diplomat overseeing it says it has stalled because of the deadlock over disarming Hamas.

Both sides have traded accusations of violations. Gaza has seen near-daily Israeli fire with more than 850 people killed in the Palestinian territory since the ceasefire went into effect in October, according to Gaza’s Health Ministry.

The ministry is part of Gaza’s Hamas-run government, but



Palestinians attend the funeral of Izz al-Din al-Haddad, the leader of Hamas’ Qassam Brigades, and his daughter and wife in Gaza City on Saturday.

AP

Highlights

- » A Hamas spokesperson, Hazem Qassem, confirmed the killing on social media
- » Six other people, including his wife & daughter, were also killed. His two sons were killed earlier in the war
- » Izz al-Din al-Haddad joined Hamas when it was established in the 1980s

staffed by medical professionals who maintain and publish detailed records viewed as generally reliable by the international community. The ministry overall says Israel’s retaliatory strikes in the war have devastated the Palestinian enclave and killed over 72,700 people.

Israel said that al-Haddad had assumed the role of Hamas commander after his predecessor, Mohammed Sinwar, was killed. The army said that al-Haddad had surrounded himself with Israeli hostages during the war as a shield against an attack. Al-Haddad’s family con-

firmed his death in Friday’s strike to The Associated Press. Six other people, including his wife and daughter, were also killed. His two sons were killed earlier in the war.

His body was wrapped in Hamas and Palestinian flags as it was carried by mourners at Saturday’s funeral in Gaza City.

Al-Haddad joined Hamas when it was established in the 1980s, and was a member of the Qassam Brigades’ Majd section tasked to go after collaborators with Israel. He was also a member of Hamas’ Military Council, the highest group of command-

ers that played a key role in the attacks that sparked the war. Israel’s army chief of staff called his killing a significant operation, and said that Israel would continue pursuing its enemies to hold them accountable.

Violence flared Saturday in the occupied West Bank, where Israeli troops shot and killed a 34-year-old Palestinian in the Jenin refugee camp, according to the Palestinian Health ministry.

Hassan Fayyad was fatally shot in a thigh, the Palestinian Red Crescent said. Israel’s military said that troops first fired warning shots at a person try-

ing to infiltrate the camp and shot him when he didn’t comply. They provided him with medical treatment as he was transferred to a hospital, it said.

Israeli troops on Thursday shot and killed a 15-year-old boy in Eastern Lubban town in Nablu, according to the Palestinian Health Ministry. Israel’s military said that it identified three people hurling rocks toward Israeli vehicles and “endangering lives,” and troops fired at them, killing one.

On Friday, settlers set fire to a mosque and vehicles in the village of Jibiya, northwest of Ramallah, Palestinian religious authorities said. Security camera footage showed people pouring flammable material on the mosque and at least two vehicles, said Sabir Shalash, the head of Jibiya’s municipal council. Spray-painted Hebrew slogans were found on the mosque’s walls, he said.

The Ministry of Awqaf and Religious Affairs described the attack as “a cowardly terrorist act” and criticized the international community’s inaction over mounting Jewish settler attacks against Muslim and Christian sites in the occupied Palestinian territories. AGENCIES

‘Islamic State group leader killed in a joint US-Nigerian mission’

WASHINGTON: US and Nigerian forces killed a leader of the Islamic State group in Nigeria in a mission carried out Friday, US President Donald Trump said.

Trump announced the joint operation in Africa’s most populous country in a late-night social media post that offered few details. He said Abu Bakr al-Mainuki was second-in-command of the Islamic State group globally and “thought he could hide in Africa, but little did he know we had sources who kept us informed on what he was doing.”

Al-Mainuki was viewed as the key figure in IS organising and finance, and had been plotting attacks against the United States and its interests, according to an official who spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to share sensitive information.

Nigerian President Bola Tinubu confirmed the operation and said Al-Mainuki was killed alongside “several of his lieutenants, during a strike on his compound in the Lake Chad Basin”.

According to the spokesperson for the Nigerian military task force that carried out the operation, the operation was a “highly complex precision aerial operation” and was carried out during three hours of darkness early Saturday without any casualties or loss of assets.

“His elimination represents the single most consequential counterterrorism outcome” in the region since the inception



US President Donald Trump

of the operation in 2015, Sani Uba, the spokesperson for the task force, said in a statement.

Born in Nigeria’s Borno province in 1982, al-Mainuki took the helm of the IS branch in West Africa after the group’s previous leader in the region, Mamman Nur, was killed in 2018, according to the Counter Extremism Project, which tracks militant groups.

Al-Mainuki was based in the Sahel area, the monitoring group said, adding that it is believed that he fought in Libya when IS was active in the North African nation more than a decade ago. He was sanctioned by the US in 2023.

Trump, in his social media announcement, said Al-Mainuki was “second in command globally”, hiding in Africa, a claim that some analysts say is off the mark. The Nigerian military, in a statement, also said intelligence shows that earlier this year, Al-Mainuki might have been “elevated to the position of Head of the General Directorate of States, placing him the second most senior leader within the ISIS global

hierarchy.”

There is no way to verify his position within IS independently. Analysts say Al-Mainuki was the deputy to Abu Musab al-Barnawi, the leader of the Islamic State West African Province who was reported to have died in 2021. He is regarded as one of the central proponents of the formation of ISWAP, after its split with Boko Haram in 2016.

“If confirmed, the killing of Al-Mainuki is huge because this is the first time a security agency has killed someone this high in the ranking of ISWAP,” Malik Samuel, a senior researcher at Good Governance Africa who specializes in insurgent groups in Nigeria, said.

“The potential to cause chaos within the group is also there because the operation must have been carried out in the heart of ISWAP’s fortified base, which is very difficult to access.”

Trump in December directed US forces to launch strikes against the Islamic State group in Nigeria, though he released little detail then about the impact.

The Nigerian military said the operation was a result of recently formed US-Nigeria partnership and intelligence-sharing efforts.

Samalia Uba, the military spokesperson, said in a statement that the operation has also “disrupted a violent terrorist network that endangered Nigeria and the broader West African region”. AGENCIES

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Letter No: 419
Office of the Executive Engineer (Civil-Maintenance), Vyasi Project, Dakpathar, invites sealed tender from interested parties. Brief summary of tenders is given below:
Tender Notice (Short Term) Date: 16/05/2026
Tender No. & Name of work: 01/2026-27/EE(C-M)Vyasi Project, "Door to Door collection of garbage form old & New Yamuna Colony, sweeping & cleaning works of old Yamuna Colony, main road from Dakpathar Tiraha to old Yamuna Colony & by pass road from tikona park to main gate of play ground near barrage at Dakpathar, Dehradun (Year-2026)".
Estimated cost -Rs. 35,43,138.00 (GST extra)
Date of availability of bid document on website-18-05-2026 From 17:00 Hrs.
Last date for submission of tender-01-06-2026 Upto 17:00 Hrs.
For fuller & further details, kindly visit e-procurement portal "http://uktenders.gov.in".
Executive Engineer (Civil-Maintenance)
"AVOID WASTEFUL USE OF ELECTRICITY"

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED
See Section 82 Cr. P.C. / 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Md. Sagar S/o Md. Rafikul Ahmad R/o Jhuggi No. 8/33, Sewa Nagar, Lodhi Road, Lodhi Colony, Delhi** has Committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 226/2023 U/s 356/379/411/34 IPC, P.S. Sarojini Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Md. Sagar** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Md. Sagar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).
Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Md. Sagar** of case **FIR No. 226/2023 U/s 356/379/411/34 IPC, P.S. Sarojini Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **30.06.2026**.
By Order
Ms. Vijayshree Rathore
Judicial Magistrate First Class -05
13, First Floor, Main Building
Patiala House Courts, Delhi

DP/6042/SW/2026 (Court Matter)

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
Tender No.: CEN-2026-27-03 Dated: 14.05.2026
E-TENDER NOTICE

Dy. CE/Const.-III/North Central Railway/Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites the following E-Tenders on prescribed form for the following works upto 15:00 hrs. on 08.06.2026. The details of the tenders are as under:-
Name of work: Construction of Project Office for monitoring projects of NCR under CAO/C & CAO/C/RSP, North Central Railway at Prayagraj.
Approx. cost of work (Rs.): 239280611.28 **Earnest Money (Rs.):** 4785600.00
Completion Period: 18 Months, **Date of Closing of tender:** 08.06.2026, **15:00 hrs., Date of Opening of tender:** 08.06.2026, **15:30 hrs., Type of tendering:** Open Tender (Two Packet System). **Note:-** 1. The Complete information along with tender document of above E-Tenders are available on Website **www.ireps.gov.in** up to 15:00 on the due date of tender opening i.e. 08.06.2026. 2. Bids other than in the form of E-bids shall not be accepted against above Tenders. For this purpose, venders are required to get themselves registered with **IREPS** website along with Digital Signature Certificates issued by CCA under IT Act-2000. 3. Payment of Bid Security deposit and tender document cost (TDC) in respect of E-tendering should be accepted through Net-Banking or payment gateway only. 4. Rates entered into Financial Rate page and duly signed digitally shall be considered. Rates and any other financial entity in any other form/letter head if attached by vendor shall be straight way ignored and shall not be considered. 5. Joint Venture (JV) shall be considered for the tender having cost more than 10 Cr. 6. Documents being attached should be signed by the tenderer on its body. 7. The tenderers shall submit a certificate as given in tender document in standard format for all items without which their tender may not be considered and shall be summarily rejected. 8. Each page of the copy of documents/certificates in support of credentials, submitted by the tenderer, shall be self-attested/digitally signed by the tenderer or authorized representative of the tendering firm. Self-attestation shall include signature, stamp and date (on each page). Only those documents which are declared explicitly by the tenderer as "documents supporting the claim qualifying the laid down eligibility criteria", will be considered for evaluation his/their tender. In case of any wrong information submitted by the tenderer, the contract will be terminated, earnest money (EMD), Performance Guarantee (PG and Security Deposit (SD) of contract will be forfeited and agency will be banned for doing business on entire Indian Railways for two (2) years. 9. GST Act & rules issued from time to time by the Government authorities shall be applicable. 10. In case of any difficulty helpdesk available on the website of **IREPS** may be approached. 11. Tender online can be submitted up to 15:00 hrs. 08.06.2026 and will be opened at 15:30 hrs. on same day.
1100/26 (D)

North central railways

www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

CPRONCR

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Aman S/o Manoj R/o C1/43 Gali No- 5 Rajapuri New Delhi Dwarka South Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 328/2023 U/s 420 IPC PS: Tilak Nagar, Delhi**, and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Aman** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Aman** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).
Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Aman** accused oft (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 328/2023 U/s 420 IPC PS: Tilak Nagar, Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **01.07.2026**.
By Order
Sh. Vikash Madaan
JMFC-07, Room No. 289
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/6437/WD/2026
(Court Matter)

कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय,
पथ निर्माण विभाग, पथ प्रमण्डल, देवघर
श्रावणी मेला, 2026
अति अल्पकालीन ई-प्रोक्योरमेंट सूचना (1st Call)
अति अल्पकालीन ई-निविदा प्रसंग संख्या
- RCD/DEOGHAR/729/2026-27
(1st Call) दिनांक -15.05.2026

1.	कार्य का नाम	सर्लसंगनगर-मिर्खोबाद पथ के कि०मी० 1st(P), 3rd(P), 4th(P), 5th(P), 6th(P), 7th(P), 8th(P), 9th(P), 10th(P), 12th(P), 14th(P), 17th(P) & 18th(P) में साधारण मरम्मत एवं अन्य कार्य (लम्बाई-18.00 कि०मी०)।
2.	प्राक्कलित राशि (रुपये में)	रुपये 1,30,00,000/- (एक करोड़ तीस लाख रुपये)
3.	कार्य समाप्ति की अवधि	36 दिन
4.	निविदा प्राप्ति की अंतिम तिथि एवं समय	01.06.2026 (12:00 बजे दिन तक)
5.	वेबसाइट पर निविदा प्रकाशित होने की तिथि एवं समय	25.05.2026 (10:30 बजे पूर्वाह्न)
6.	निविदा आमंत्रित करने वाले पदाधिकारी का पदनाम	कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय, पथ निर्माण विभाग, पथ प्रमण्डल, देवघर।
7.	प्रोक्योरमेंट अधिकारी का सम्पर्क नम्बर	06432-299919
8.	ई-प्रोक्योरमेंट सेल का हेल्पलाईन नम्बर	0651-2446007

नोट - अतिरिक्त जानकारी के लिए वेबसाइट <http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in> पर देखें।

प्राक्कलित राशि घट-बढ़ सकती है।

कार्यपालक अभियंता, पथ निर्माण विभाग, पथ प्रमण्डल, देवघर

PR 380005 Road(26-27).D

SYMBOLIC POSSESSION NOTICE
Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No.-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi- 110005

The Authorised ICICI Bank Officer under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notices to the borrower(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the Notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice.
Having failed to repay the amount, the Notice is issued to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken symbolic possession of the property described below, by exercising powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property. Any dealings with the property will be subject to charges of ICICI Bank Limited.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Loan Account Number	Description of Property/ Date of Symbolic Possession	Date of Demand Notice/ Amount in Demand Notice (Rs)	Name of Branch
1.	Santosh Kumar Srivastava-Deceased (Through His Legal Heir/ Renu Srivastava/ LBND000004142292	Flat No F-3, 1st Floor, Lig. Back Side (Without Roof Rights) Built On Plot No-m-172 Situated At Sector-12, Residential Colony Prastap Vihar Tehsil & District Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh- 201001/ May 14, 2026	January 14, 2026 Rs. 20,31,414/-	Delhi/ Ncr
2.	Manoj Chowdhary/ Raju Chowdhary/ LBGHZ00004835281	Flat No.1003,10th Floor,(Without Roof Rights) In Tower/Block-C In Star Rameshwaram, Nh 58, Raj Nagar Extension, Village Noor Nagar, Ghaziabad- 201001 (Along With Covered Car Parking), Owned By Manoj Chowdhary/ May 14, 2026	January 28, 2026 Rs. 18,93,404.48/-	Delhi Ncr/ Gorakhpur
3.	Shreya Mittal-Deceased Through Her Legal Heir/ LBDEL00006653335/ LBDEL00006652485	Property Bearing No.98, Upper Ground Floor, Khasra No.61/61, Constructed On Plot No.33/6, Situated At Ram Nagar Extension, Village Khureji Khas, Shohdara, Delhi- 110051/ May 14, 2026	December 17, 2025 Rs. 42,62,411.48/-	Delhi/ Ncr

The above-mentioned borrowers(s)/guarantors(s) is/are hereby issued a 30 day Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold after 30 days from the date of publishing this Notice, as per the provisions under Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.
Date: May 17, 2026
Place: Delhi/Ncr

Sincerely Authorised Officer,
For ICICI Bank Ltd.

COURT NOTICE
(U/o 5 Rule 20 CPC)
(UNDER GUARDIAN AND WARD ACT)
IN THE COURT OF
Ms. Anuradha
Civil Judge (Senior Division),
Hisar
SHALINI GOYAL
Vs.
GENERAL PUBLIC
PETITION FOR GRANTING PERMISSION TO SELL SHARE OF MINOR ARADHYA GOYAL
CNR No. HRHS02-001128-2026
Next Date:-06-07-2026

NOTICE TO: GENERAL PUBLIC :-
Hisar
In above titled case, the defendant (s)/respondent(s) could not be served. It is ordered that defendant(s)/ respondent(s) should appear in person or through counsel on **06-07-2026 at 10:00 am**.
For details login to **<https://highcourtcdg.gov.in/?mod=distRICTnotice&district=Hisar>**
Sd/- Ms. Anuradha
Civil Judge (Senior Division),
Dated 07-05-2026
Hisar,

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Jafar S/o Shahid Ali, R/o H.No. E-16K-450, New Seelampur, Delhi**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 361/2018, U/S 379/411/34 IPC, PS Kashmir Gate, North Distt., Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Jafar** cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Jafar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).
Proclamation is hereby made that **Jafar** the said accused of **FIR No. 361/2018, U/S 379/411/34 IPC, PS Kashmir Gate, North Distt., Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **20.07.2026**.
By Order
Sh. Vaibhav Garg
Judicial Magistrate First Class-11,
Central Distt., Court No.-138, 1st Floor,
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/6395/N/2026
(Court Matter)

कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय,
पथ निर्माण विभाग, पथ प्रमण्डल, देवघर
श्रावणी मेला, 2026
अति अल्पकालीन ई-प्रोक्योरमेंट सूचना (1st Call)
अति अल्पकालीन ई-निविदा प्रसंग संख्या
- RCD/DEOGHAR/737/2026-27 (1st Call)
दिनांक -15.05.2026

1.	कार्य का नाम	सिखिया आश्रम से बिहार बॉर्डर (दरदमारा) पथ के कि०मी० 1st(P), 2nd(P), 4th(P), 5th(P), 6th(P), 7th(P), 8th(P), 9th(P), 10th(P), 11th(P), 12th(P) & 13th(P) में साधारण मरम्मत एवं अन्य कार्य (लम्बाई-12.49 कि०मी०)।
2.	प्राक्कलित राशि (रुपये में)	रुपये 2,00,00,000/- (दो करोड़ रुपये)
3.	कार्य समाप्ति की अवधि	36 दिन
4.	निविदा प्राप्ति की अंतिम तिथि एवं समय	02.06.2026 (12:00 बजे दिन तक)
5.	वेबसाइट पर निविदा प्रकाशित होने की तिथि एवं समय	26.05.2026 (10:30 बजे पूर्वाह्न)
6.	निविदा आमंत्रित करने वाले पदाधिकारी का पदनाम	कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय, पथ निर्माण विभाग, पथ प्रमण्डल, देवघर।
7.	प्रोक्योरमेंट अधिकारी का सम्पर्क नम्बर	06432-299919
8.	ई-प्रोक्योरमेंट सेल का हेल्पलाईन नम्बर	0651-2446007

नोट - अतिरिक्त जानकारी के लिए वेबसाइट <http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in> पर देखें।

प्राक्कलित राशि घट-बढ़ सकती है।

कार्यपालक अभियंता, पथ निर्माण विभाग, पथ प्रमण्डल, देवघर

PR 380010 Road(26-27).D

Allen key in Knight show

Finn, Raghuvanshi, Green lead KKR past GT, keep hopes alive

KOLKATA: Finn Allen smashed a sensational 35-ball 93 while Angkrish Raghuvanshi produced a composed unbeaten 82 as Kolkata Knight Riders kept their IPL playoff hopes alive with a commanding 29-run victory over Gujarat Titans on Saturday.

Asked to bat first, KKR unleashed a batting onslaught to post a daunting 247 for 2, with Allen setting the tone through a breathtaking display of power-hitting. The New Zealand batter tore into the Gujarat bowling attack from the outset, hammering 10 sixes and four boundaries during his explosive knock.

Allen and Raghuvanshi added 95 runs in just 41 balls for the second wicket, putting KKR firmly in control after an aggressive start. While Allen played the aggressor's role, Raghuvanshi anchored the innings brilliantly, mixing timing with calculated aggression.

After Allen's dismissal, Raghuvanshi continued the charge alongside Cameron Green, who chipped in with an unbeaten 52. The duo stitched together a 108-run partnership off only 53 deliveries to ensure KKR finished with one of their highest totals of the season.

Raghuvanshi remained unbeaten on 82 off 44 balls,



KKR's Finn Allen brought up his fifty off just 21 balls

BCI

striking fluently against both pace and spin, while Green provided the finishing touches with a powerful late assault.

Chasing a massive target, Gujarat Titans fought hard but were always behind the asking rate despite useful contributions from their top order. Captain Shubman Gill led the response with an elegant 85 off 49 balls, while Jos Buttler

smashed 57 from 35 deliveries to keep GT in contention briefly.

Sai Sudharsan, who had retired hurt earlier in the innings, returned later to score an unbeaten 53 off 28 balls, but the target ultimately proved too steep. KKR's bowlers managed to hold their nerve despite the batting-friendly conditions. Veteran spinner Sunil Narine

delivered a key spell, finishing with figures of 2 for 29 and breaking important partnerships at crucial moments. Saurabh Dubej also chipped in with a wicket.

For Gujarat Titans, Mohammed Siraj and Sai Kishore picked up a wicket each but struggled to contain the relentless KKR batting line-up.

MP0ST

Batting in-stability hurt us: DC coach

NEW DELHI: Delhi Capitals assistant coach Ian Bell on Saturday admitted that batting inconsistency has thwarted his side's campaign in the IPL 2026, and urged batters to step up and support in-form KL Rahul.

Rahul has made 477 runs this season from 12 matches, but other batters have struggled. "When you look at the top four teams at the moment, there is a lot of consistency in the batting line up. I think over a period of time now, not having that stability in the batting line up is something we are obviously working towards," Bell told the media ahead of DC's match here against Rajasthan Royals. "KL has again had a fantastic year. But we need other people to step up as well and be more consistent. I don't think anyone quite yet has made himself undroppable by performance."

AGENCIES

Satwik-Chirag dig deep in semis, one win away from title



Chirag Shetty and Satwiksairaj Rankireddy won in three games

FILE

It feels good. We didn't start of the year that well, we were also not good mentally because of not a really good start

Chirag Shetty

years of battling injuries and setbacks have made them mentally tougher.

Satwik and Chirag, the Asian Games champions, were forced to withdraw from major tournaments such as the Asia Championships and the

Swiss Open, where they pulled out in the quarterfinals, due to Satwik's recurring shoulder injury. "We are used to it now. There was a phase when we kept wondering why it was happening, but later I realised it is part and parcel of the game," Satwik told BWF.

"The way we play is very attacking, so there will always be a few niggles. I have a history of tears and similar issues, so, I have to manage myself and keep playing."

"It's about adjusting, staying calm, and supporting each other. Even when I'm not fully fit, my partner has always been supportive. Tan coach has also handled injured players very well, and that has made a big difference. I'm really happy."

AGENCIES

SPARKS SET TO FLY

With the ISL crown at stake, MBSG take on EB



For Mohun Bagan, this is a chance to move closer to a historic third title

PTI

NEW DELHI: Arch-rivals East Bengal FC and Mohun Bagan Super Giant will clash in the penultimate round here on Sunday with the ISL title hanging in the balance, adding another dramatic chapter to one of Indian football's fiercest rivalries.

For years, the derby has largely been one-sided in the ISL era.

East Bengal struggled badly after entering the top-tier league, finishing ninth four times and 11th once in five seasons. Against Mohun Bagan, their record has been even worse: nine defeats and one draw in 10 meetings.

But this season feels different. Under Spanish coach Oscar Bruzon, East Bengal have transformed from perennial underachievers into genuine title contenders. The gap between the two Kolkata giants has narrowed considerably and for the first time in years, the derby appears evenly poised.

The Red-and-Gold brigade

Tomorrow is one final. A player and coach wants to play game like this

Sergio Lobera , MBSG coach

are chasing their first national top-flight league title in more than two decades, having last won the then National Football League in 2003-04 under Subhas Bhowmick.

Bruzon, who took charge during a derby in 2024 after arriving in Kolkata only hours before kickoff, now stands on the verge of scripting a remarkable turnaround before departing the club at the end of the season on May 31. "We are in a positive mood. No plan no talks. Everyone has other ideas. I want to focus on the game," Bruzon said.

AGENCIES

Defending champions RCB smell playoffs against struggling PBKS

NEW DELHI: Royal Challengers Bengaluru would look to exploit vulnerabilities of a profligate Punjab Kings bowling line up to seal a play-off berth in the Indian Premier League here on Sunday.

In the only day game scheduled at the scenic Dharamsala stadium, the draw without an iota doubt is Virat Kohli, fresh off a hundred in the previous game.

A sizeable number of fans have already made their way up to the mountains from Delhi and Punjab to see the larger than life Kohli bat in the breathtaking backdrop of Dhauladhar range. The limited infrastructure in place in the city is pushed to its limits.

Defending champions, the only team which has maintained consistency throughout the tournament, are clear favourites against Punjab Kings, who are in a freefall having lost five games in a row after being the most dominant team in the first half of the tournament. While RCB are sitting comfortable on the points table, a sixth loss for Punjab Kings would effectively shut the play-off door on the Shreyas Iyer-led side.

In both the games played



Virat Kohli during a training session on Saturday

PTI

In both the games played here, Punjab Kings failed to defend 210 and 200

here, Punjab Kings failed to defend 210 and 200 after failing to control the last five overs. In fact, they have lost the most the numbers of games (10) after posting 200 plus total in the format's history.

The team needs to rejig its bowling combination with the likes of Xavier Bartlett and Marco Jansen proving expensive throughout the tournament. Arshdeep Singh has

managed to bring his economy rate under 10 with his frugal returns in the last game while Azmatullah Omarzai made instant impact with bat and ball in his first game of the season.

Vijaykumar Vyshak has been out of the side and perhaps the team goes back to him in search of much needed control in the middle and death overs. The batting department, which has done well overall, is not firing on all cylinders in the last few games but it is the bowling that has let the team down repeatedly. The pitch has offered seam movement thus far and was on the slower side in the MI-PBKS fixture. RCB, on other hand, are playing like a well oiled machine.

AGENCIES

Lewandowski to leave Barcelona

BARCELONA: Prolific scorer Robert Lewandowski will leave Barcelona at the end of the season, the Spanish club said Saturday.

The Poland striker, who turns 38 in August, was widely expected to be on the move with his contract set to expire. Lewandowski joined

Barcelona from Bayern on a 45 million euros transfer in 2022, when his new club was in serious financial trouble and still reeling from the exit of Lionel Messi. Lewandowski was seen as a key piece of its rebuilding effort. He went on to help Barcelona win three La Liga titles.

Audacious Semenyo goal fires Man City to FA Cup title

LONDON: In its 155-year history the FA Cup final can rarely have been won by a more audacious goal.

Manchester City beat Chelsea 1-0 at Wembley Stadium on Saturday thanks to a moment of magic from Antoine Semenyo.

The forward brought to life a final that had produced little in the way of chances or excitement with a spectacular back-heeled goal in the second half. Running onto a cross from Erling Haaland in the 72nd minute, Semenyo flicked his heel at the ball and directed it low into the far corner past diving Chelsea goalkeeper Robert Sanchez.

Victory kept City in the hunt for a domestic trophy treble, having already won the English League Cup. Pep Guardiola's team is also second in the Premier League, two points behind Arsenal with two rounds to go.



Antoine Semenyo scored a brilliant backheel goal

AP

This was Guardiola's 17th major trophy in 10 years at City and his 35th in his career overall. City have won the Cup eight times and moved level with Chelsea, Liverpool and Tottenham as equal third on the all-time winners' list.

Defeat means Chelsea will end the season trophy-less — a year after being crowned Club World Cup

champion — in what has been a crisis-ridden campaign. After firing two coaches since the turn of the year, Chelsea went into the final with a novice on the sideline in Calum McFarlane, a former youth coach taking charge of only his seventh first team game. The turmoil at Chelsea led to supporters staging a protest against its American owners outside

the stadium before kickoff. In that sense it was commendable that McFarlane was able to frustrate Guardiola for such long periods. That was until Semenyo's match-winning moment. The Ghana international joined City from Bournemouth only in January and made an immediate impact — scoring 10 goals.

AGENCIES

17
This was Guardiola's 17th major trophy in 10 years at City and his 35th in his career overall

Bihar Urban Infrastructure Development Corporation Ltd.
A Government of Bihar Undertaking
NOTICE INVITING Re - TENDER
NIT No: Buidco/Yo-3210/2025- 34
(Through e-procurement2.bihar.com only – www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in)

Gr.No	Name of work	Estimated Cost (Rs in Lakh)	Bid Processing Fee	Bid Document Cost (in Rs)	Bid Security (EMD) (Rs in Lakh)	Time of completion
1.	नगर पंचायत रूपौली (पुणेगुं) क्षेत्रांतर्गत एस० एच० – ६५ गुला खलू से रूपौली गाँव वार्ड स०- ०१ के रास्ते रूपौली थाना चौक तक सड़क एवं नाला निर्माण साथ ही रूपौली थाना चौक से प्रखंड कार्यालय गेट होते हुये एस० एच० – ६५ के किनारे रूपौली नहर तक नाला निर्माण कार्य।	546.61267	As Per Belton Norms	23600.00	10.94	12 Months
2.	नगर निगम, कटिहार क्षेत्रांतर्गत वार्ड स०- 26, 34 एवं 35 पटेल चौक से तीनगछिया बाजार समिति एवं करिया होते हुये बंदिनी चौक तक पथ एवं नाला निर्माण कार्य।	1252.08527		29500.00	22.52	12 Months

1

Date of downloading of bid document

: From 20.05.2026 to 04.06.2026 up to 03:00 PM Through website www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in

2

Place & Date of Pre-bid meeting

: Date 23.05.2026 Time 03:30 PM. BUIDCO, Near Rajapur Pul, West Boring Canal Road, Patna-800001 (Pre Bid query also may send on pdh@buidco@gmail.com). Query will not be accepted after 23.05.2026 at 05:00 PM. Query will not be considered after than above mail Id.) Date 04.06.2026 up to 04:00 PM Through website www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in

3

Last date and time for receipt (upload) of bids

: Date 05.06.2026 up to 03:00 PM at Buidco HQ, rajapur pul patna 800001 and Office of Respective Project Director, Buidco.

4.

Last Date and time for Submission of hard copy of EMD

: Date 05.06.2026 Time 04:00 PM

5.

Time and date of opening technical bids

: To be communicated later on

6.

Time and date of opening of financial bids

: Through website www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in

7.

Place of opening of bid

: 120 days

8.

Period of bids validity

: Chief General Manager, BUIDCO

9.

Officer inviting bids

: For further details please visit : www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar
Chief General Manager(N) BUIDCO, Patna

PR- 003365 (B & C) 2026-27

नशे से बचने का है एक ही उपचार, दृढ़ संकल्प और परिवार से प्यार।

RITES LIMITED
(A Government of India Enterprise)
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PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED
(See Section 82 Cr. PC/)
(84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **Irshad S/o Dilawar R/o Jhugli No 21/334, Indira Camp Kalyanpuri Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 373/2023, U/s 25/54/59 Arms Act at PS: Mandawali, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Irshad** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Irshad** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Irshad of FIR No.373/2023, U/s 25/54/59 Arms Act of PS: Mandawali, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 30.07.2026.

By order
Sachin
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
East District, Court No.16
Karkardooma Courts Delhi

DP/6209/ED/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
(See Section 82 Cr.P.C)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Ravi Kumar @ Ravi Sharma**, Punjab Milk Product At H-11, Karampura, New Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence CC No. 87/2016 u/s 138 N.I. Act at P.S. Prashad Nagar, New Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Ravi Kumar @ Ravi Sharma** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Ravi Kumar @ Ravi Sharma** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proceeding u/s 82 Cr.P.C has been initiated in the case. Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Ravi Kumar @ Ravi Sharma** accused of CC No. 87/2016 u/s 138 N.I. Act at P.S. Prashad Nagar, New Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on 21.09.2026.

By Order: Sh. Arvind Tomar,
Judicial Magistrate First Class-02 (NI Act)
Court No. 507, Extension Block,
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/6386/CD/2026

AUTHOR



DIPANKAR DEY

Almost all aspects of democracy registered a dramatic reversal compared to 25 years ago, observes the Varieties of Democracy Institute (V-Dem). The 10th edition of 'Democracy Report 2026, titled "Unravelling the Democratic Era?", published in March this year, paints a stark picture of the state of democracy worldwide, highlighting that the global levels of democracy have fallen back to those last seen in the late 1970s. By the end of 2025, more countries are classified as autocracies (92) than democracies (87), and nearly three-quarters of the world's population (74 per cent) – around six billion people – live under autocratic rule. Only a small minority, approximately 7 per cent, reside in liberal democracies. The report also highlights the continued expansion of what V-Dem terms the "third wave of autocratization". Notably, this trend is no longer confined to fragile or transitional regimes but increasingly affects established democracies like India, the USA and Brazil. At the end of 2025, four of the world's most populous countries are autocracies (India, China, Indonesia, and Pakistan). The USA, under Donald Trump, is rapidly autocratizing, the report says.

A third wave of autocratization – a contemporary, ongoing trend, starting around 2010, is characterized by a global decline in democratic governance, where established democracies are experiencing backsliding through gradual, legally-driven, and often electoral means rather than sudden military coups. In 2019, autocracies outnumbered democracies for the first time since 2001. Unlike the two previous, rapid autocratization waves (1920s–40s, 1960s–70s), this wave is marked by a gradual stealth- a cautious, unobtrusive, and secretive way of authoritarian shifts, intended to avoid detection. An empirical study by Lührmann, A., & Lindberg, S. I. (2019) suggests that democratic backsliding is a recurring, cyclical phenomenon rather than a solely linear progression, with projections showing global democracy may not return to its 2010 peak until roughly 2042.

Electoral autocracy is the most populous regime type in 2025, and subjects nearly half of the world population – 46 per cent (3.8 billion) – to itself. India, Pakistan, and most recently also Indonesia, are among the most populous electoral autocracies in the world.

DIGITAL SURVEILLANCE- A CHALLENGE TO DEMOCRACY

The rise of digital surveillance constitutes one of the most significant threats to democracy and human rights in the 21st century. Recent reports linking Microsoft's cloud infrastructure to Israeli surveillance operations targeting Palestinians raise questions over Big Tech accountability and involvement in the Gaza genocide. The Guardian revealed that Israeli intelligence agencies were using Microsoft servers to run a mass surveillance operation targeting Palestinian communications. According to the Guardian's investigation, the Israeli military secretly stored a vast database of Palestinians' phone calls on Microsoft's servers in Europe. The system, operational since 2022, was capable of storing and processing recordings of approximately one million calls per hour made by Palestinians.

Digital surveillance, once widely viewed as a hallmark of authoritarian regimes, has now permeated democratic states under the narrative of progress, economic growth, and public safety. This development presents complex risks to democracy itself, privacy rights, and civic freedoms, according to political analysts. Though historically, digital surveillance practices were seen as fundamentally

incompatible with democracy, these technologies are now increasingly framed as necessary, neutral, or even beneficial for purposes like customisation of services, economic innovation, or public health.

Countries such as China, Russia, India, Turkey, and the United States employ facial recognition, biometric databases, and artificial intelligence to monitor populations extensively. Digital platforms have pivoted into tools for both manipulation and repression. Social media algorithms designed to maximise engagement often prioritise sensational and polarised content, facilitating the rise of misinformation and echo hollows that degrade democratic discourse. Experts note that the weaponisation of digital tools extends to silencing opposition, censoring dissenting voices, and controlling the

flow of information. The mass collection and processing of personal data by states and corporations alike compromise individual autonomy, safety, and dignity—core pillars that uphold democratic society. The unchecked growth of sophisticated surveillance tools—biometrics, artificial intelligence (AI), driven monitoring, data profiling—coupled with the profit motives of tech companies, imperils the democratic project worldwide.

AI's influence on politics has evolved over the years. In the early days of artificial intelligence (AI), concerns centred on its potential to spread 'deepfakes' and propaganda in politics. Today, however, AI is reshaping the political landscape by transforming how campaigns operate and how candidates communicate. SFLC.in – a citizens' initiative that works for 'digital

freedom' observed an uptick in the number of instances where various political parties – both regional and national are increasingly using generative AI tools to their aid in the recently held elections in India. The use of AI tools to push their campaigning efforts is witnessed in all types of medium – audio, video and images; across platforms. Here are a few illustrations they cited:

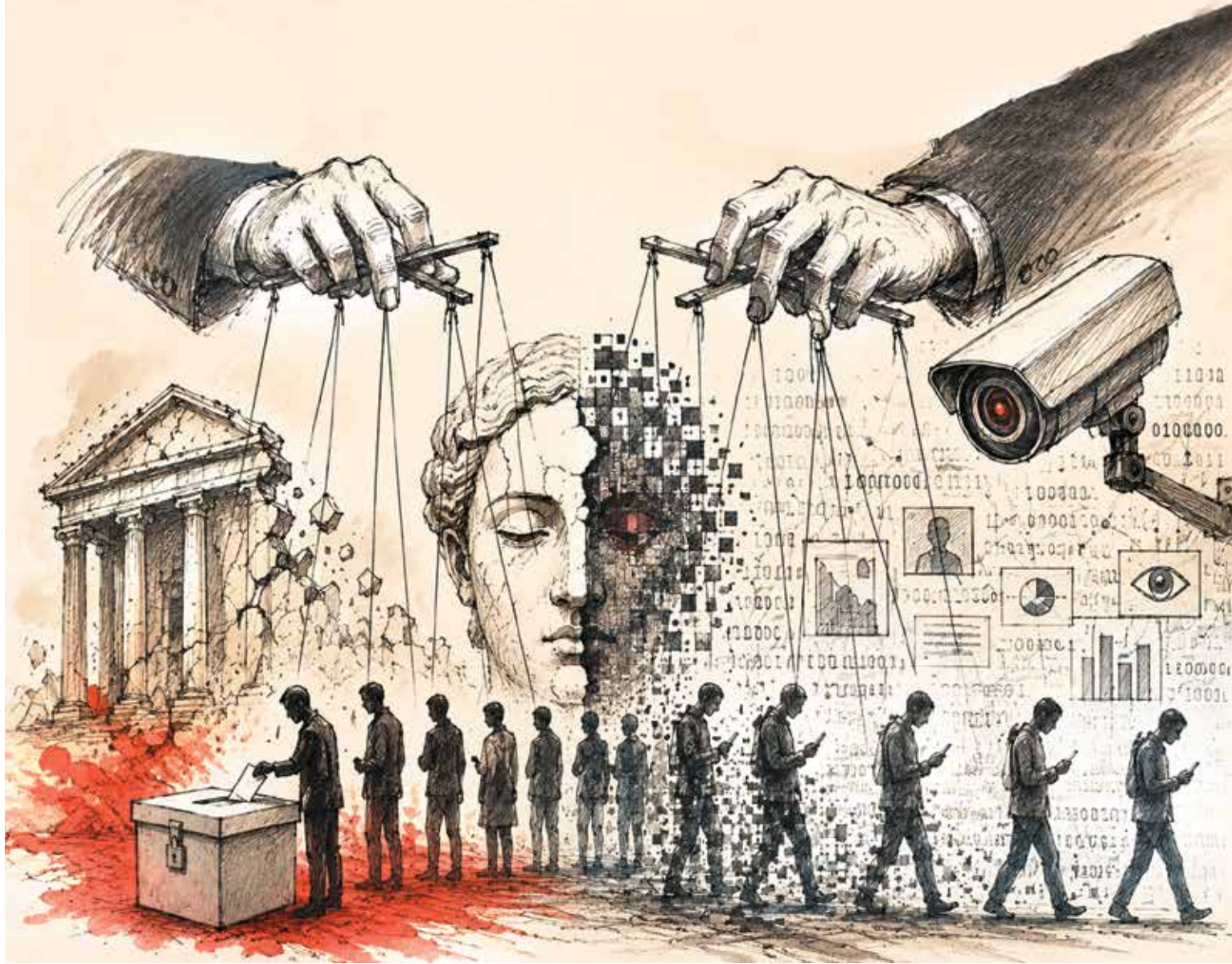
- » In an election campaign video by Tamil Nadu Congress, the deceased politician Kamaraj deepfake appeared to urge citizens to vote for Congress. There was no disclaimer denoting the video as "AI-generated".
- » In the official election

campaign video from All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK), there are AI-generated clips of yesterday's deceased politicians, J. Jayalalithaa and MGR, passing on their legacy to Edappadi K. Palaniswami.

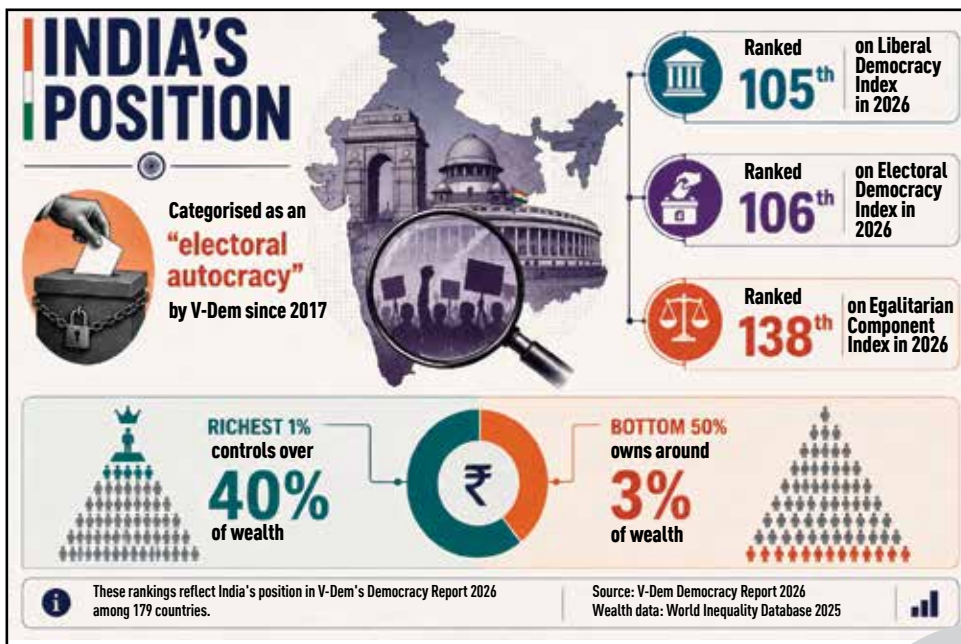
- » An AI-generated video shows Kerala CM and Opposition Leader attending a BJP Event in disguise and appreciating the BJP's campaigns for the upcoming election. The video lacks any clear, prominent label such as "AI-Generated".
- » A video posted in X opens with AI-generated scenes showing a peaceful Hindu family engaged in daily worship. Then it abruptly shifts to riot footage showing Muslim mobs stone-throwing, burning Hindu homes, and creating chaos during protests against the Waqf Amendment Act. The clip blames the AITMC government of West Bengal for encouraging Muslim appeasement and division, framing the events as targeted anti-Hindu riots. It ends with an emotional appeal from Hindu victims seeking safety and restoration of their lives, concluding with the hashtag #BancheChaiBJPTai ("We want to live, that's why BJP"), positioning the BJP as the party that will protect Hindus ahead of the 2026 West Bengal elections. The video lacks any clear, prominent label such as "AI-Generated", "Digitally Enhanced", or "Synthetic Content" covering at least 10 per cent of the visible area.

DEMOCRACY IS NOT COLLAPSING OVERNIGHT; IT IS BEING QUIETLY REDESIGNED THROUGH technology WEALTH AND CONTROLLED CONSENT

Global March of Autocracy?



AS AUTOCRACY EXPANDS WORLDWIDE, DIGITAL SURVEILLANCE, AI-DRIVEN POLITICS AND EXTREME INEQUALITY ARE RESHAPING THE FOUNDATIONS OF DEMOCRATIC LIFE



THE THIRD WAVE

WHAT DEFINES MODERN AUTOCRATIZATION?

- Gradual erosion, not Sudden Coups**
- Electoral and legal methods used for control**
- Institutions remain, independence weakens**
- Media and judiciary face sustained pressure**
- Digital surveillance becomes central to governance**

success of capitalism through the use of brutal force. The market has become the main mechanism for economic coordination and the maximisation of profits. The global competition of economic systems has been clearly won.

After the collapse of the Soviet empire, neoliberal capitalism was able to flourish. In 1989, Francis Fukuyama wrote his famous essay on the "end of history". Fukuyama predicted this end in two respects: political and economic liberalism had finally decided the world-historical race of systems in their favour. Fukuyama was absolutely right about capitalism prevailing. But he was on the wrong track when he believed that democracy would also prevail worldwide. Since 2010, the world has been living in a phase of democratic regression. The same is not true for capitalism.

In a recent interview, citing the examples of the post-Soviet states like Russia and Ukraine with their oligarchic capitalism, Wolfgang argued that though capitalism and democracy follow different logics, under certain conditions, they can engage with each other. Then, a space of possibility emerges where they can coexist- not only with capitalism, but also with deeply autocratic systems. Politics leaves selected oligarchs a certain space in which they can operate freely- thus democracy and capitalism are forcibly married.

Globally, the concentration of wealth has significantly widened since 2010, with a dramatic acceleration in fortunes at the top of the economic pyramid. As of late 2025, the top 1 per cent of adults hold roughly 45–48 per cent of global wealth, a significant increase in concentration from previous years. The number of billionaires roughly doubled in the 10 years following the 2008 financial crisis. By 2025, billionaire wealth will have increased by 81 per cent since 2020, with fortunes growing three times faster than in 2023. The bottom half of the global adult population owns only about 1.3 per cent of total wealth, with this segment seeing a decline in its share over the past decade. Technology and Artificial Intelligence are the main drivers of inequality and rapid fortune creation. The same trend is observed in India, where the richest 1 per cent controls more than 40 per cent of total wealth, while the bottom 50 per cent own merely 3 per cent.

Since 2017, India has been categorised as an "electoral autocracy" in the V-Dem's democracy reports. This year, out of 179 countries, India ranks 105th on the liberal democracy index. Last year, it ranked 100. On the electoral democracy index, it is 106, on the liberal component index, it is 99, and on the egalitarian component index, it is 138. In an AI-dominated electoral autocracy, Indian democracy is in danger as citizens' views are constantly engineered by the autocratic state to influence the voting process. Deletion of millions of citizens from the voters' list during the SIR, carried out by the Election Commission, where AI tools were extensively used in the recently concluded elections in states of West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Bihar and Kerala, are cases in point.

Time Magazine (November 21, 2025) notices that "the last decade taught us painful lessons about how social media can reshape democracy: misinformation spreads faster than truth, online communities harden into echo chambers, and political divisions deepen as polarisation grows. Now, another wave of technology is transforming how voters learn about elections—only faster, at scale, and with far less visibility. Our research suggests their influence is already rippling through our democracy".

'CAPITALISM IS NOT DEMOCRATIC, DEMOCRACY NOT CAPITALIST'

Merkel, Wolfgang (2014) in his seminal article titled, "Is capitalism compatible with democracy?", argued that capitalism and democracy follow different logics: unequally distributed property rights on the one hand, equal civic and political rights on the other; profit-oriented trade within capitalism in contrast to the search for the common good within democracy; debate, compromise and majority decision making within democratic politics versus hierarchical decision-making by managers and capital owners. 'Capitalism is not democratic, democracy not capitalist', he concluded. According to Wolfgang, throughout the past two centuries, capitalism and democracy have proven themselves the most successful systems of economic and political order. Following the demise of Soviet-style socialism after 1989 and the transformations of China's economy, capitalism has become the predominant system around the world. Only a few isolated countries, such as North Korea, have been able to resist the



From rather uncertain beginnings to its new-found safety and leadership in EVs, Tata Motors has scripted one of India's most dramatic automotive turnarounds

Tata Unboxed

AUTHOR



RAJEEV NARAYAN

There was a time when owning a Tata car was less a purchase and more a public confession. The panel gaps were legendary. The doors shut with the acoustic elegance of a steel cupboard tumbling down a staircase. Taxi operators swore by them; private buyers swore at them.

In the automotive hierarchy of the early 2000s, Tata Motors occupied an awkward middle lane. It was too industrial for aspirational buyers, too utilitarian for enthusiasts and too inconsistent to challenge the polished dominance of Maruti Suzuki. Similarly, the Korean precision of Hyundai Motor Company and the characteristic oomph of the German brigade were pipedreams for Tata Motors.

Those were the days when the Indica was mocked mercilessly. The Nano, despite its engineering audacity, became a cautionary tale about confusing affordability with aspiration. And yet, somewhere between humiliation and reinvention, Tata Motors pulled off one of the most fascinating corporate turnarounds in modern Indian industry.

Today, the company that once struggled to convince Indians to buy hatchbacks is lecturing the industry on safety, electrification and design language. Its SUVs dominate conversations. Its electric vehicles have become India's EV gateway drug. And its once-ridiculed badge now carries a curious blend of nationalism, ruggedness and technological ambition.

The following question is thus unavoidable: was this brilliance, luck, timing? Or was it simply survival instinct masquerading as strategy?

NEAR COLLAPSE

The turnaround did not emerge from strength. It emerged from near-collapse. For years, Tata Motors was trapped in an identity crisis. It was fundamentally a truck-maker trying to behave like a passenger car company. Then came the audacious acquisition of Jaguar Land Rover from Ford Motor Company for \$2.3 billion in 2008, a deal widely mocked at the time as corporate overreach bordering on insanity. The timing itself was bad. The global financial crisis exploded months later. Debt ballooned. Demand collapsed. Analysts circled like vultures. Many believed Tata Motors had purchased two glamorous British headaches just when the world stopped buying luxury cars.

But the improbable happened soon. JLR became Tata Motors' cash engine



for much of the following decade. Range Rover and Defender transformed into global luxury icons, helping Tata Motors fund its domestic ambitions. By FY 2024-25, JLR had delivered its 10th consecutive profitable quarter and generated £1.5 billion (then around Rs 15,000 crore) in free cash flow.

This foreign acquisition did something more important too; it changed Tata Motors psychologically. Exposure to global engineering, design systems and premium branding began filtering back into India. Slowly, almost reluctantly, the company started learning how modern carmakers think.

SAFETY GOSPEL

Then came the masterstroke: Safety. For decades, India's car buyers largely prioritised mileage, resale value and monthly EMIs. Safety ratings were treated like optional footnotes. Tata Motors recognised the shift before most rivals did.

The Nexon's five-star Global NCAP rating changed everything. Suddenly, Tata was no longer selling cars; it was creating moral superiority. WhatsApp groups turned into amateur crash-test tribunals. Parents lectured children on structural integrity between discussions on mutual funds and cholesterol.

The company rode the wave. Harrier, Safari and Punch were positioned not as SUVs, but as symbols of masculinity and responsibility. Even critics admitted the company had discovered something rare in Indian manufacturing – emotional appeal.

There were still quality inconsistencies, software glitches and after-sales horror stories. Social media remained littered with jokes about niggling electronics and service-centre roulette. But buyers kept buying. Because Tata had achieved something more difficult than perfection: it had become relevant.

ELECTRIC SURGE

If safety gave Tata Motors respectability, electric vehicles gave it dominance. India's EVs remain embryonic by global standards, but Tata moved before competitors understood the shift. While rivals debated policy incentives and charging infrastructure, Tata flooded the streets

with Nexon, Tiago and Punch EVs. The strategy was not glamorous; it was practical, brutally so.

The company understood a simple truth: India's EV revolution would not begin with luxury sedans, but with upper-middle-class urban anxiety over petrol prices. By 2025, Tata controlled the bulk of the passenger EV market. The company transformed itself into the default EV choice for early adopters. Today, spotting a Tata EV in India's city traffic is no longer a novelty; it is routine.

Yet, beneath the success lies a complicated reality. Analysts continue warning about margin pressure, rising competition and overdependence on JLR. And Tata Motors remains vulnerable to geopolitical shocks, tariffs and slowing luxury demand abroad. Commodity costs and global instability are hitting margins, even as the company pushes premiumisation and electrification.

Analysts flag structural risks surrounding EV profitability, global demand weakness and JLR's exposure to China and Western markets. In other words, the turnaround story is still being written.

INDIAN LESSON

It is the still-underway story that makes Tata Motors so compelling. Unlike polished fairy tales scripted by consultants, this comeback still carries dents, contradictions and uncertainty. The company remains capable of producing both brilliance and bafflement, sometimes in the same quarter. Yet, its growth teaches a larger lesson for India's manufacturing ambitions.

For decades, Indian auto firms excelled at software, services and frugal improvisation but struggled to build aspirational consumer brands with global relevance. Tata Motors challenged that assumption. It demonstrated that an Indian manufacturer could absorb humiliation, survive ridicule, learn painfully and eventually disrupt its own market.

The irony is delicious. The company once dismissed as an automotive laggard now dictates dictums on safety and electrification while several global giants scramble to catch up. But disruption is never permanent. Chinese EV makers are looming. Software-defined vehicles are rewriting the industry. Hydrogen, hybrids and battery geopolitics could alter the landscape again within years.

Tata Motors' challenge now is not reinvention. It is avoiding complacency after reinvention. Because history offers a cruel warning: in the auto sector, yesterday's disruptor can become tomorrow's dinosaur. For the road ahead rarely forgives companies that start believing their own advertisements.



CAN CLIMATE MODELS GUIDE POLICY?



Climate models remain essential for policymaking, but scientists increasingly warn against treating them as infallible predictors of the future

AUTHOR



KRISHNA GUPTA

We saw that climate models are not ideally suited to predict climate decades or centuries from now. This is because climate is changing in unpredictable ways and the rate of change itself is uncertain. To add to that, many of the assumptions made in climate models to represent local or small-scale processes (referred to as parameterisation) pose problems in prediction.

Finally, many of the IPCC models, such as the Representative Concentration Pathways (RCPs) and Shared Socioeconomic Pathways (SSPs), which have been referred to above, have made some implausible assumptions. For example, one of the RCP models assumes that the use of coal in the next 70-80 years will rise six-fold by 2100, when it may have already peaked. The problem is that the IPCC models are used in many research papers in the sciences and social sciences, and the errors creep in there as well. We are back to the question: how can climate models help in public policymaking and decision-making? Let us discuss this in greater detail.

APPLICATIONS TO PUBLIC POLICY

Outputs of climate change models, such as temperature, rainfall, wind velocity, etc., are generally available at the grid level, which tends to be a cell of dimension 100 km by 100 km. To make this useful at the local level, results of GCM simulations are integrated with historical observations at the regional or city level. One such attempt was made by combining GCMs with Auto Regressive Integrated Moving Average (ARIMA) models to give city-based predictions for temperature and rainfall for engineering applications (for more details, the article by Lai and Dzombak, published in the *Journal of Meteorology and Climatology* in May 2021, may be referred to).

In his book *Predicting Our Climate Change*, David Stainforth has argued that GCM or ESM models have limitations and cannot be used to predict climate accurately. Instead, he says that an alternative would be to look at local time series of important variables such as temperature, rainfall and humidity, and assess the probability of their crossing a defined threshold. These thresholds could be those that are important for various things, such as overheating risks or the ability of humans to work beyond a certain temperature. Stainforth also warns against pushing for the "perfect" climate model, for there can be no such thing.

Instead, the focus should be on how best to achieve specific objectives to reduce the risks from climate change and better adapt to climate change. Stainforth also lays great store by a multidisciplinary approach to climate change and its consequences, where social science and physical science should be in constant dialogue.

Another approach was proposed by Swiss researchers Reto Knutti and Markus Huber, who looked at a time series of data on temperature and humidity from around the world for each day since 2000. From this data, they extracted a "fingerprint" of radiative forcing (warming caused by greenhouse gases, aerosols, etc.) and used this to separate anthropogenic warming from natural warming. They take this to be evidence of global warming and climate change.

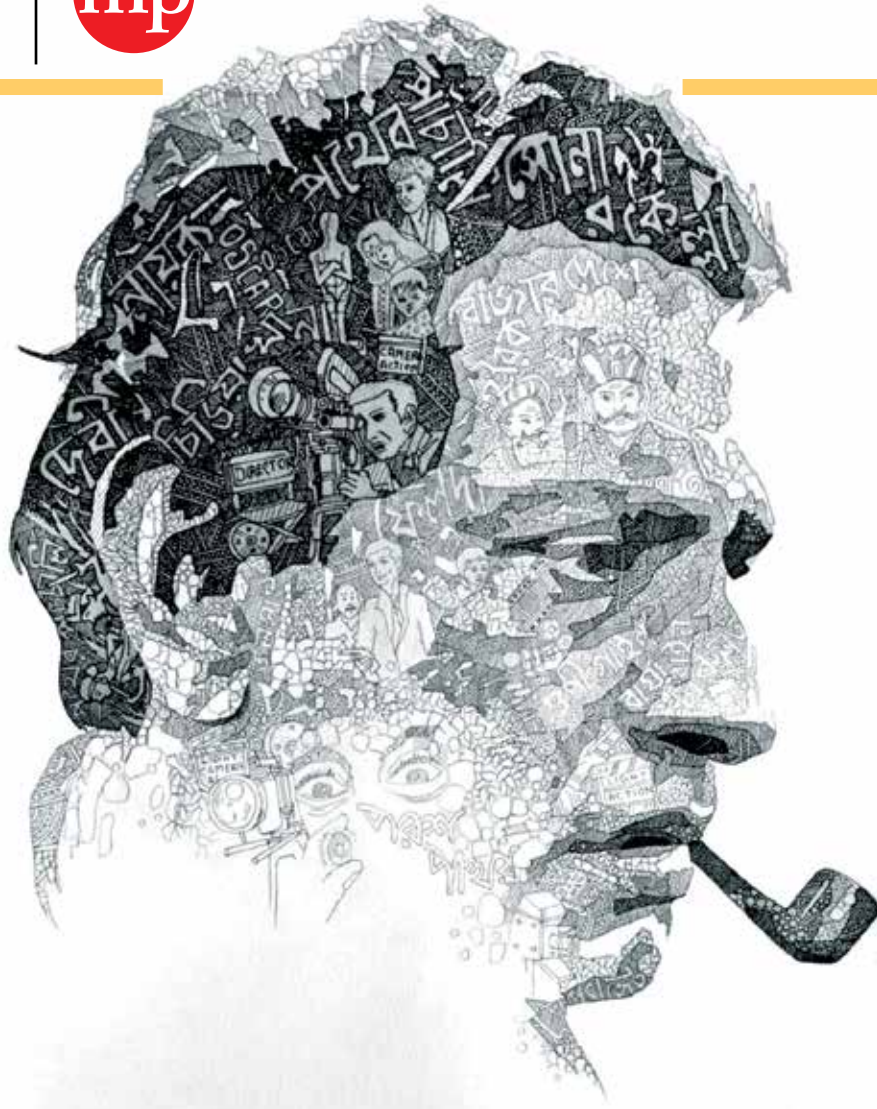
Another recent example of climate models being used in policy is that of the UK Climate Projections 2018 (UKCP18 for short). The UKCP18 used GCMs and Regional Climate Models to predict rainfall, temperature, storm intensity and sea-level rise till 2100, and used these projections to make an infrastructure plan to mitigate flood risks. Similarly, NASA's sea-level rise prediction model has been used by New York City planners for better coastal planning.

THE USE OF COAL will rise six-fold by 2100, by which time its consumption would have peaked, says a study

In the *Climate Change* series of articles over the last year or so, we have covered various aspects of mitigation and adaptation. Many of these, such as policies in the energy, transport, agriculture and industry sectors, have benefited from the various outputs of climate models and the comparisons run under CMIP by the IPCC. Issues such as Net Zero pathways, to which each country has committed, decarbonization, energy transition, creation of climate-resilient infrastructure and the phase-out of fossil fuels have perhaps been decided on the basis of climate model simulations.

CONCLUSION

Climate change models are a useful tool, but not a panacea for managing all climate change consequences or even for predicting future climate. Economic models such as the Integrated Assessment Models (IAMs) also have their limitations, as we discussed in an earlier article. It is also true that the basic laws of physics have established that climate change is a reality, and that global warming has not only been happening as a result of human intervention but will also accelerate if timely action is not taken. Hence, the best way forward is to recognise the limitations of models and work with the data to see how our objectives on mitigation and adaptation can be met.



Reading Ray

Beyond the Screen



Through cinema, poetry and philosophy, the book revisits Ray as a humanist whose art continues to transcend borders

AUTHOR



SUBHORANJAN
DASGUPTA



It is not that I have not read other books on him written by fascinated critics like Marie Seton and Robin Wood, or that I have not focused on those memorable dialogues in which he articulated his aesthetic credo and commitment. But still, even after journeying through this long and fervent homage voiced by many, I believe we should all concentrate on this many-faceted interpretation by Chinmoy Guha, which explores regions hitherto uncharted.

Why do I make this explicit claim? First, because the author in the twenty chapters, which constitute this book, has created a single symphonic eulogy out of two different movements, Orient and Occident or East and West, that unravel the singular mastery of the maestro. In other words, he has explored how the cinematic art of Jean Renoir and the artistic dedication of Nandalal Bose (his tutor in Shantiniketan) coalesced in his creativity, beginning from the *Apu Trilogy* and ending with *Aguntuk/Visitor*.

While engaged in this dual though related commitments, Ray depicted the paradigmatic human condition which is rooted to a particular soil and, at the same time, devoted to the universal essence. Thus, as Robin Wood has said, Apu and Durga turned into incomparable archetypes. In his words, "Ray is arguably the cinema's greatest director of children." Or, to take another potent example, Biswambhar in *Jalsaghar/The Music Room*, which roused Paris, came to embody the inescapable decay of the feudal lord



“My admiration for Satyajit Ray is total. I am very thankful to him because through his films I have known India with a deep insight”

— MICHELANGELO ANTONIONI



“The secret of good film-making is editing. This calls for an uncanny sense of timing. Satyajit Ray is the only director in India who has it”

— RITWIK GHATAK

everywhere in this world, unable to survive the assault of avaricious mercantilism. In his very own way, Balzac had performed a comparable function in the history of French Literature. He explored the decline of royalist France, that is, the inevitable social transformation in the human condition, as experienced by Friedrich Engels, his most diligent reader.

Apart from these reasons mentioned above, Guha, an ardent student of literature and literary theory, has made consummate use of poetry and criticism to widen the range of our response. I shall limit myself to one specific example in this context — his masterly utilisation of T.S. Eliot's celebrated thesis in his essay *Tradition and Individual Talent* and his unforgettable

poem *Four Quartets*. Both construct that palpable intimacy between two related forms of creativity, literature and cinema, pen and camera. Chinmoy reminds us of Francois Truffaut's eulogy to buttress this connection. Truffaut described Ray as the "master of *auteur* (author) cinema, capable of creating music with 'images'."

While reading the author's excellent explication of *Charulata*, I became even more intensely aware of this particular metamorphosis from one language to another. Only Ray could turn that impeccable novella *Nastanir* into an impeccable film. Indeed, what he achieved was exemplary. He utilised enviably the tragic fragments of a conjugal relationship to paint a society layered with the shades

of new impulses and emerging tensions in a colonial society trying to bask in the sunshine of segmented reform.

Perhaps, yet another remarkable feature of this book is its emphasis on the nature of Satyajit's political aesthetic cum sociopolitical commitment. He himself phrased it succinctly in the following terms, "People say that I don't commit myself. I commit myself to human beings, that's a good enough commitment for me." No wonder, this inherent adherence to his trademark of ethics prompted him to expose the cruel amorality of corporate mercantilism in *Seemabadha/Confined by Limits* without being a provocateur, provoked his hero in *Pratidwandi/Rival* to single out the militant defiance in Vietnam as the most historic event of the last century and inspired him to spell out his redemptive vision in his very last film *Aguntuk/Visitor*. In point of fact, the very distinctiveness of his commitment kept him apart from the pronounced aesthetic of the other two greats, Ritwik Ghatak and Mrinal Sen. Fortunately so, the three contemporaries etched their varying socio-cinematic agendas and, in the process, offered us a splendid variety of corrective attachment to the world that enveloped them.

Above all and everything, he was a superlative narrator like Balzac and Manik Bandyopadhyay, and this is transcribed in the dialogues which he carved, delivered by his characters. Five such dialogues constitute the last section of the book and the more you dwell on them, the more you realise the unsullied authenticity of V.S.

Naipaul's comment, "He seems to achieve more and more with less and less."

This tribute reminds me of the maestro's own critique. I asked him once, "Why do you rate Utpal Dut's *Tiner Talwar/The Tin Sword* as the most remarkable Bengali play and production of our times?" His answer was compellingly unequivocal, "Utpal showed, just in 2½ hours, the grave and tragic limitations of our vaunted Bengal Renaissance on the stage. Our best historians devote pages on this same very anomalous subject." This revealing reply underlines the precisely crafted eloquence of his creativity as well. The fingers of Charu and Bhupathi did not meet ultimately, that wordless separation explained all.

I would have been even more delighted if the author had devoted one chapter — it could have been brief — on Ray's memorable documentary on Rabindranath. He himself wrote the text of this film and lent his booming voice. Both together etched the kindred points of heaven and home by capturing the sacred privacy of the poet and the indomitable protest of his social being, both interrelated inextricably.

Finally, he could have recalled the sustained tribute paid by Salman Rushdie, who said that he simply 'grew' up with his films. I recall that the two protagonists in Rushdie's immaculate fairytale *Haroun and the Sea of Stories* were christened Goopy and Bagha. No admiration could be more deep-rooted and intrinsic than this dependence on names.

The Story India Sewed Together

Navtej Sarna traces the fascinating evolution of India's national flag through rebellion, symbolism, politics and identity

AUTHOR



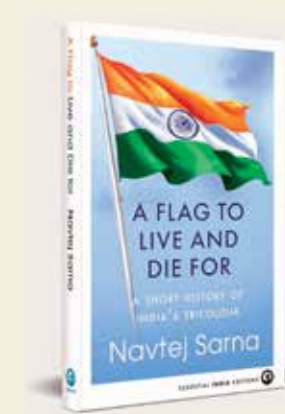
NAVTEJ SARNA

In *A Flag to Live and Die For: A Short History of India's Tricolour*, Navtej Sarna begins his story by drawing our attention to the very first chapter of the Bhagavad Gita. While describing the scene on the battlefield of Kurukshetra, we get a description of the flags of the most important warriors and military commanders: Arjuna carried the *kapi-dhvaja* — with the ensign of Lord Hanuman; Bhima's standard had the image of a lion; Yudhishtira's flag bore a pair of *mridangams*; while Duryodhana exhibited a serpent on his standard. Flags are also seen in Kautilya's *Arthashastra* as markers of royal persona, authority, as well as territory. Among the Rajputs, the Ranās of Chittor saw themselves as Suryavanshis (descendants of the sun) and had a crimson flag with the sun at the centre. The Mughal flag — known as Alam — was made of scarlet and green cloth, featuring a crouching lion and a rising sun. Soon after the British Crown took over the administration of India from the East India Company (EIC), the

Viceroy — who was also called the Knight Commander of the Star of India — was given a flag that carried the imperial symbol of the Union Jack along with the crown and a star in homage to the new honorific. However, another important change that took place was that the flags moved from the traditional triangular pennant to the rectangular format favoured in most of Europe, along with heraldic symbols.

As expected, the official flag of British India was not accepted by the nationalists, and they decided to create their own flag(s). The first in the series was the double-pennant flag designed by a twenty-three-year-old young man, Srish Chandra Bose, who paraded through the streets of Lahore in 1883 to protest the imprisonment of Surendra Nath Banerjee for writing against a judge of the Calcutta High Court in his paper *The Bengalee*. The Lahore of that time was indeed one of India's most cosmopolitan cities, the other, of course, being Calcutta, which had been shaken to the core by Curzon's unpopular decision to partition Bengal in 1905.

On the first anniversary of this day, Bhupendra Nath Dutt, the younger brother of Swami Vivekananda, presented a *Vande Mataram* flag to Surendra Nath Banerjee. This had been designed by Sachindra Prasad Bose and Sukumar Mitra and was the first tricolour, with three horizontal stripes of red, yellow and green, and eight half-open lotuses representing the eight provinces of British India, along with a sun and crescent moon to represent



Hindus and Muslims respectively. The words "Vande Mataram" were inscribed in Devanagari script in deep blue in the middle of the yellow stripe. The same flag was hoisted by Dadabhai Naoroji at the Congress session held in Calcutta that year, where each of the 1,600 delegates also wore a badge with the same design. However, after the annulment of Partition, this design receded from public memory.

Meanwhile, Swami Vivekananda's Irish disciple, Sister Nivedita, designed another flag for India, which had the *Vajra* (thunderbolt) at the centre of a rectangular scarlet flag. One hundred and eight *gyotis* (oil lamps) decorated the border, and *Vande Mataram* was inscribed in Bangla; this is currently preserved in the erstwhile residence of Acharya Jagadish Chandra Bose.

A year later, in August 1907, another woman, Bhikaji Cama, unfurled the Indian flag at the International Socialist Conference



in Stuttgart. This was on the lines of the Calcutta *Vande Mataram* flag, with three stripes of green, golden saffron and red, eight lotuses on the green stripe, and misspelt versions of "Vande Mataram" on the saffron stripe, with the sun and the crescent moon on the red stripe. In a slight departure from this emerging pattern came the flag of the Home Rule movement — five red and four green horizontal alternating stripes with the Union Jack in the top left-hand corner, a crescent moon and a star to the right, and seven stars across the stripes.

We now turn to the remarkable Pingali Venkaya of Pedakallepali village in Krishna district, Andhra Pradesh, who published a slim volume called *A National Flag for India* with no fewer than 24 alternate designs. He displayed all of them at the Congress sessions and also urged the Congress to invite more designs from the public. The rainbow became a leitmotif

for the seven religious sects of the country, with white representing Jains. The lotus, Lakshmi, Saraswati, Kali, Bhishma, Arjuna, the trishul, the peacock, bow and arrow, Mount Kailash, the vajra, and nineteen stars representing nineteen languages of the country also found a place on the flag. While the Mahatma was not too impressed with this medley of colours and symbols, at the Vijayawada session of the Congress in 1921, he turned to Venkaya to design a flag with a spinning wheel on Khadi cloth. The Mahatma acknowledged that the idea came from Lala Hansraj of Jullundur (now Jalandhar). Thus came the Swaraj flag on coarse Khadi — with white on the top (for all minorities), followed by green (for the Muslims), and red for Hindus as the base — the idea being that

"the strongest should act as a shield for the weakest."

In the years that followed, the Swaraj flag became a symbol of nationalist protest and resistance; from July 1923, it was decided that Flag Day would be celebrated across the country on the last Sunday of every month at 8 a.m. Hoisting and saluting of the flag would be followed by the singing of the National Anthem. This was the flag unfurled by Jawaharlal Nehru on the left bank of the Ravi, under the shadow of the Lahore Fort, on the night of December 29, 1929, as a symbol of national unity: the "national flag of Hindustan". It was under this flag that Congress members

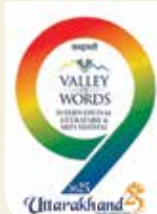
took the pledge and read the declaration of *Purna Swaraj*.

Yet there were murmurs of dissent about the communal colours of the flag. In 1931, the Congress set up a seven-member Flag Committee — Pattabhi Sitaramayya (convenor), Jawaharlal Nehru, Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, Maulana Azad, Master Tara Singh, Dr N.S. Hardikar and D.B. Kallekar — to decide on the final contours of the national flag. The response that resonated most with the members of the committee came from Suniti Kumar Chatterji, the editor of *Modern Review*, who wrote that "equating the colours of the flag with any

religion or community would be pernicious and anti-national; rather, the colours should represent ideas and aspirations of universal significance". Finally, the committee decided that "the colours shall be saffron, white and green in the order stated here, from top to bottom, with the spinning wheel in dark blue at the centre of the white stripe, with the colours standing for qualities, not communities". Saffron was to represent courage and sacrifice, white stood for peace and truth, and green represented faith and chivalry. The *charkha* stood for the hope of the masses. It was decided to celebrate August 30 as Flag Day — and it was hoisted on public buildings, municipalities, district boards, as well as educational institutions. One was even smuggled into the precincts of Alipore Jail, where it was put up in one of the wards as a mark of celebratory defiance!

CHAKRA OVER THE CHARKHA

Just before Independence, the issue of whether to replace the *charkha* with the *chakra* came up. Savarkar was among the vociferous supporters of the *chakra* — for it symbolised progress and strength. Finally, the committee under the president of the Constituent Assembly, Dr Rajendra Prasad, decided that the emblem on the flag should be "the exact reproduction of the wheel on the capital of Ashoka's Sarnath pillar, superimposed (in dark blue) in the middle of the central band (white) of the flag". This, in its final and current iteration, is the flag we live and die for.





The sixes may dominate highlight reels, but pace bowling, tactical discipline and Virat Kohli’s unmatched hunger continue to shape the season’s defining moments

Beyond Sixes and Spotlight

AUTHOR



S KANNAN

The Indian Premier League is not a burial ground for all fast bowlers. Those willing to hurl the white ball with pace, extract movement and hit a good line are still being rewarded. With the 2026 edition of the IPL now in the “business phase”, where the Top Four will make the cut, defending champions Royal Challengers Bengaluru and Gujarat Titans continue to grab headlines. We have heard repeatedly this year that the IPL has become a batting festival, where sixes are unleashed from the start. Yes, stats will suggest that “maximum” is in order, something the crowd loves. It sends them into raptures, even as the commentators wield microphones and YouTubers raise their pitch. There are also the “Wailing Banshee” types who have said this IPL is a death knell for fast bowlers. Cricket was always about a contest between bat and ball. For those who may have forgotten, in an era bygone, the West Indies pace battery would make batsmen (now batters) hop, skip and jump. Speed merchants like the late Malcolm Marshall, Michael Holding, Andy Roberts, Joel Garner and company would reduce Test matches to a heavyweight boxing slugfest where opponents were crushed in no time. Imagine, we fans have seen some famous batsmen fearing for their own lives and broken rib cages. At that time, nobody said, “Stop this nonsense, let runs be scored!”

Ahh, for those who wail, those who crib, sport is all about gladiatorial contests. There will always be something or the other to complain about if you do not enjoy sport as a spectacle in totality. Amidst the cacophony and viewership numbers in the IPL dropping this year, what is clear is that performers are always noticed. There is no such thing as fatigue, since the IPL is being held after the ICC T20 World Cup. Imagine,

PACE IS NOT DEAD



The narrative that IPL 2026 has become a graveyard for fast bowlers is being challenged strongly by Gujarat Titans. Mohammed Siraj and Kagiso Rabada have shown that pace, discipline and movement still matter in T20 cricket. Rather than relying entirely on 220-plus batting totals, GT’s strategy has revolved around taking wickets in the

Powerplay and applying sustained pressure. Under coach Aashish Nehra, Gujarat’s bowling-first approach has become one of the defining tactical stories of the season. Their success also proves that even in an era dominated by six-hitting and batting analytics, quality fast bowling continues to remain cricket’s greatest equaliser.

tickets and “passes” were sold on the black market at a petrol pump in New Delhi, near the Ferozeshah Kotla, now renamed the Arun Jaitley Stadium. Unethical, yes, but it tells you there is still a demand for seats inside the arena. And, in Bengaluru, the demand for free passes from MLAs in the Karnataka Assembly had reached such bizarre levels that the BCCI was forced to shift the final from the Chinnaswamy Stadium to the Narendra Modi Stadium in Ahmedabad. For those who say this is not a sporting city, it is a lie. Ahmedabad has evolved and, from cricket to a Coldplay rock concert, there is demand. Today’s youth are willing to travel to a city which offers so much.

Perhaps, trying to send a strong message that Ahmedabad is a level playing field and not just a batter’s paradise, Gujarat Titans’ fast bowlers have shown speed, spine and daring to catch the eye. Imagine, after an average start, they are swiftly making changes in their strategy. At a time when bowlers are being portrayed as “victims”, what Kagiso Rabada and Mohammed Siraj have provided is sheer delight, defining what home advantage is all about. It has been delightful to watch these fast bowlers evolve as a pair. There are two more speed merchants as well who ensure the GT pace-driven attack is potent and capable of winning matches at home.

A bit about the team led by Shubman Gill. As captain, he deserves credit for ensuring the side is doing well this season. The way Gujarat’s new-ball pair has operated in the Powerplay has been defining. Without going too much into statistics, the message from Gujarat is

clear: they have bowlers who can deliver and do not necessarily have to rely on scoring over 200 runs as a challenging total to put up first.

When a team does well, the captain comes in for praise. Yet, if one looks at Gujarat Titans over the years, how coach Aashish Nehra has been behind the team every minute is important. He is the man who shaped the destiny of the team when Hardik Pandya was in command. Now at Mumbai Indians, Hardik looks lost, almost junked by the franchise which bought him for a massive price. Nehra, as a left-arm swing bowler when he delivered for India, was a class act. His is the case of someone who could have done much more had he not been dealing with so many injuries. Never mind. As a smart coach in the IPL, he has rich experience and shares it with great relish. The Delhi man is a bundle of energy, egging on the bowlers and fielders. It is as if he behaves more like a football manager barking orders rather than a cricket coach in pyjama-coloured clothing. It shows Aashish Nehra’s involvement and how he is constantly in the middle of it.

It takes one fast bowler of Nehra’s experience, and the support from Aashish Kapoor, another proven hand in IPL coaching, to show that Gujarat Titans will rely more on wickets in the Powerplay than centuries from their batters. Yes, GT have also been well-served by Shubman Gill and Sai Sudharsan. The trick now is to sustain the tempo and go right through till the end. As things stand, Gujarat should qualify for the Last Four, but nothing can be left to chance.

The way Punjab Kings have seen a

loss of form, thanks to bowling lapses and poor fielding, has caused them trouble. Off-the-field incidents have also bothered them, be it Arshdeep Singh travelling with his girlfriend against BCCI rules or Yuzvendra Chahal being caught “vaping”. The IPL cannot be treated as a party zone when in full public view. These days, when professional cameras and cellphone cameras have intruded into private space, there can be no complacency. Shreyas Iyer, the captain of Punjab Kings, as well as owner Preity Zinta, are aware that the focus must only be on cricket till the end.

Reports of unwanted people being seen with the team and players have been noticed. The very concept of girlfriends being present with players is serious, since anti-corruption regulations come into play. Indian cricket has seen, in the past, what damage has been caused by needless folks hanging around cricketers. That the BCCI has warned teams sternly is a good sign. Surely, the IPL can do without controversies like “honey traps”, as there is so much at stake.

Talk of focus and how the IPL’s biggest star stays focused — it was a delight to see Virat Kohli come out smoking against Kolkata Knight Riders and plot victory in Raipur. After two ducks, for Kohli to show that he is still master of the chase needs to be highlighted. Cricket has become not only about stats but also in-depth data analysis. Strike rate, dot balls, sixes — all this is part of the jargon.

And yet, when you see Virat Kohli batting, it is a state of nirvana for the fans. No sweat, no worry, just watching the artist at work, scripting a chase. To slam a ton was like a monk in meditation. How long can this Virat show go on, dominate the field of play, decimate the rival bowling attack and dictate how he will shape results for RCB? It is not about one day or one year. To be with the same franchise for 19 years and show that same passion — Virat Kohli has emerged as the presiding deity at RCB. It does not matter whether he is batting in Bengaluru or Raipur. The show must go on; fans must sit back, enjoy and cheer.

Behind the runs and records, there is a superhuman constantly challenging age, fitness and the bar itself. There are two rock-star Indian athletes who have defined performance under pressure. If anything, the more the pressure, the more defining the response has been. In decades gone by, tennis maverick Leander Paes mocked ranking and reputation in a theatre called the Davis Cup. This year marks three decades since Leander won an Olympic bronze medal at the Atlanta Olympics. Lee spoke of pressure being a catalyst for him to peak on the big stage.

Cricket and tennis are different. Yet, for all those who heard Virat Kohli speak after the latest century in Raipur, there was a big message: keep challenging oneself, compete against the best. Each day at work is a delight. Where he almost made you choke was when he said one day this will end — his El Clasico in the IPL. For all those who have bullied him on social media and ensured he quit Test cricket on his own terms, the ODIs and the IPL are his personal space. Kohli is pushing hard; he leaves the rest behind by a mile, even if comparisons are made with MS Dhoni and Rohit Sharma in the IPL.

Muhammad Ali called himself “The Greatest”. If the IPL needs to decorate someone with this tag, no guesses, it can only be King Kohli. Did I hear a fan say in Hindi, “Mat ruko, Virat bhai”? He has, after all, said the show will end one day. One just hopes it is delayed as much as possible. The IPL needs Virat Kohli. Dil se!



HISTORIC APPOINTMENT

Former England keeper Sarah Taylor has been appointed England men’s Test fielding coach for the New Zealand series, becoming the first woman to coach a senior men’s international team. The 36-year-old, a World Cup winner and widely regarded as one of cricket’s finest wicketkeepers, replaces Carl Hopkinson on a short-term basis.



QUARTERFINAL EXIT

P. V. Sindhu bowed out of the Thailand Open after losing a hard-fought women’s singles quarterfinal to top seed Akane Yamaguchi on Friday. Sindhu won the opening game but eventually went down 21-19, 18-21, 15-21 in the Super 500 tournament clash lasting over an hour.



CLASSIC WIN

R Praggnanandhaa defeated Javokhir Sindarov with black pieces in round two of the Super Chess Classic Romania in Bucharest. The defending champion moved to 1.5/2 after avenging two earlier defeats to Sindarov at the 2026 Candidates, defending precisely after accepting a knight sacrifice.

Here are seven shows set to take over the year and define just how far YA's takeover era really goes

7 YA: The Moment of 2026!

OUR CORRESPONDENT

In 2026, the YA genre isn't just trending; it's setting the context for what people are watching. It dominates watchlists, fuels fandoms, generates various fan edits with stan accounts and not-so-quietly sets the rules for what hits with audiences. From the cultural chokehold of 'The Summer I Turned Pretty' and the endless 'Team Jeremiah vs Team Conrad' rivalry to the spiralling intensity of 'Euphoria', coming-of-age stories continue to define pop culture by capturing the messy, overwhelming emotions of growing up.

Here are seven shows set to take over the year and define just how far YA's takeover era really goes!

ELLE



Season one of 'Elle' rewinds the clock to 1995, following Elle Woods before she ever set foot in Harvard. Set in the chaos of high school, she navigates tricky friendships and first love, all while leaning on her family, especially her close bond with her mother. As she faces each challenge, the series traces the making of the confident icon we know and adore! 'Elle' from the world of the much-loved film 'Legally Blonde', premieres on 'Prime Video' on July 1.

EUPHORIA

Few YA shows have managed to become as visually iconic and emotionally chaotic as 'Euphoria'. From its glitter-soaked aesthetic and hypnotic soundtrack to its raw portrayal of addiction, identity, love and self-destruction, the series has built a cultural grip that extends far beyond television. 'Euphoria' thrives in its ability to make chaos feel cinematic and season three doesn't disappoint! The new season is now streaming on 'JioHotstar'.

OFF CAMPUS



In 2026, the YA genre isn't just trending; it's setting the context for what people are watching

Based on the bestselling book series, 'Off Campus' is a college-set romance drama centred on an elite ice hockey team and the women in their lives, as they navigate love, heartbreak and self-discovery while stepping into adulthood. Season one focuses on the opposites-attract dynamic between quiet songwriter Hannah and Briar University's star athlete Garrett, blending chemistry with emotional growth. 'Off Campus' is now streaming on 'Prime Video'. Heated rivalry hockey fans, keep an eye out for this one!

OUTER BANKS

While exact details of Outer Banks' final season are still buried like hidden treasure, the stakes are higher than ever. Picking up after season four, the Pogues are drawn into a revenge-driven hunt for the Blue Crown treasure after JJ Maybank's death, with Chandler Groff escaping to Portugal with it. Expect another globe-trotting adventure before a final return to North Carolina, as the series heads toward a high-stakes conclusion this year on 'Netflix'.



MAXTON HALL: THE WORLD BETWEEN US S3



Season three raises the stakes as Ruby is suspended from Maxton Hall, with all signs pointing to James, putting both her Oxford dreams and their relationship at risk. As secrets surface and class divides deepen, the two are forced to confront

whether love and friendships can survive when everything around them begins to fall apart. The new season premieres this year on 'Prime Video' and honestly, we can't wait for this one!

MARFIL



If there's one thing YA fans can't resist, it's a dangerously complicated slow burn. 'Marfil' follows Marfil Cortés, whose perfect New York life unravels after a sudden kidnapping. Back under her father's watch, she's paired with a guarded bodyguard, Sebastian Moore, sparking a tense attraction. As they return to Spain and new threats surface, their dynamic plays out in a world where nothing is as it seems. 'Marfil' is set to release on Prime Video this year.

STERLING POINT



'Sterling Point' follows 17-year-old Annie Jacobson, whose New York life is upended when she inherits her estranged grandfather's island in Canada. Alongside her twin brother and adoptive father, Annie steps into a world of new friendships, first love and long-buried family secrets. Blending small-town intimacy with emotional discovery, the series leans into a softer, introspective side. Premiering on 'Prime Video' on August 5, 'Sterling Point' already has all the ingredients of a coming-of-age obsession waiting to happen.

Taken together, these titles prove one thing: YA in 2026 isn't just having a moment; it is the moment. It's messy, romantic, adventurous, comforting and just a little bit unhinged, all at once. Whether it's giving you soft love stories to obsess over or high-stakes drama to spiral about, the genre knows exactly how to keep you hooked and talking. Right now, this genre isn't just leading the charge - it's running our entire feeds and watchlists!

'YOU DON'T LET NOISE GET TO YOU'



Constructive criticism is something that Sara Ali Khan implements 80 per cent of the time

Constructive criticism is something that Sara Ali Khan implements 80 per cent of the time. However, the actress said it is equally important to block out the noise as she navigates a career where she has had her fair share of successes and failures.

Sara, daughter of actors Amrita Singh and Saif Ali Khan, said her mother, in fact, warned her about overnight success after the release of her debut 'Kedarnath' and 'Simmba'.

"I know that I got a lot of love very early in my career, very, very early. And my mom, in fact, used to tell me, 'This is very scary, because it happened overnight and it was a lot. Then came two films that didn't give me that love and that was actually scarier. So, I was like, 'Okay, what's happening?' But I've grown to see that if you do good and honest work, the audiences will give you love for that," the actor told PTI in an interview.

After the initial hits, the actress's next two projects, 'Love Aaj Kal' and 'Coolie No 1', failed to click with the viewers. However, her performance in 'Atrangi Re' was praised.

Sara said some films will resonate with audiences while others may not work and all she can do is keep her head down and continue working hard, which is exactly what she is focused on doing.

"You just hope for the best and you keep working. You don't let the noise get to you. You have to see, 'What if this is constructive criticism?'. 'Where do people have a point?' or 'Okay, fine, maybe this is true. Maybe I do have to be more aware of my surroundings. Maybe I shouldn't just let my personality be so loud that people refuse to take me seriously'. These are things that have been told to me and I implement them 80 per cent of the time. And then you are aware that ultimately your work will speak. If people give you that chance, which I'm lucky enough to have gotten, then hopefully they'll like me. And if not, I'll try harder," she said.

Sara, who was last seen in 'Sky Force' and the multi-starrer 'Metro... In Dino', is currently promoting her new theatrical outing 'Pati Patni Aur Woh Do', which also features Ayushmann Khurrana, Wamiqa Gabbi and Rakul Preet Singh.

Directed by Mudassar Aziz, the film is a follow-up to the 2019 movie 'Pati Patni Aur Woh', which was a remake of Sanjeev Kumar's 1979 film of the same

name.

In the film, described as a comedy of errors, the story is about Prajapati (Ayushmann), a man caught between three women, played by Sara, Rakul and Wamiqa.

The 30-year-old said she is looking forward to 'Pati Patni Aur Woh Do', which, despite its title, is a film that can be watched with the entire family.

"You can watch it with your children and grandparents. You don't have to shut their eyes and ears. They can watch the whole film. It's just been a while since I've felt that there is this community watching wholesome collective experience giving films out there in theatres," she said.

Sara, who completed eight years in Hindi cinema this year, said it feels like just yesterday when she was working on 'Kedarnath', her debut with Sushant Singh Rajput, who passed away in 2020

Shooting for the film was also a fun experience for the actress, who praised her co-star Ayushmann for his natural ease on the sets of the movie. The duo is also collaborating for the upcoming drama 'Udta Teer'.

"He is always just cracking jokes. Keeping it light. He doesn't take himself seriously at all, which is not something I honestly expected when I first worked with him. This is my second film with him now. In the first film, during the first couple of days, I wouldn't talk to him. I was like, 'Ayushmann... He must be a serious type. I won't go. I'll say something'. And then he was laughing one day, two days, three days. I was like, 'Okay, you know what? I think he could be a funny person'. And then we started laughing and joking," said Sara.

Sara, who completed eight years in Hindi cinema this year, said it feels like just yesterday when she was working on 'Kedarnath', her debut with Sushant Singh Rajput, who passed away in 2020. PTI

LUKKHE: DRIVEN BY BETRAYAL & SURVIVAL

From powerful debuts to standout performances, here are five reasons why 'Lukkhe' hits differently

OUR CORRESPONDENT

The rise of Indian hip hop may form the backbone of Prime Video's 'Lukkhe', but at its core, the series is a gritty crime thriller driven by revenge, ambition, betrayal and survival. Set in a volatile world where rivalries spiral dangerously out of control, 'Lukkhe' blends crime, emotional conflict and high-stakes action into a story that feels intense, chaotic and deeply human. Beneath all the swagger and aggression lies a world full of fractured relationships, dangerous loyalties and characters constantly battling their own demons. From powerful debuts to standout performances, here are five reasons why 'Lukkhe' hits differently.

KING's acting debut: One of the biggest curiosities was always KING's acting debut and the show smartly places him in a role that works with his existing aura while also demanding emotional depth. As MC Badnaam, he carries the rage, swagger, vulnerability and exhaustion of someone constantly trying to survive in a



ruthless world. Whether he's dealing with betrayal or consumed by revenge, there's a natural ease to his performance that makes the character feel believable and lived in.

A cast that delivers: What makes 'Lukkhe' work is that nobody feels out of place in its messy and emotionally volatile world. Shivankit Parihar, largely known for his comic timing and relatable screen presence, completely catches you off guard with his menacing performance. Raashii Khanna brings emotional intensity and depth as Gurbani; Lakshvir Saran adds sincerity and restraint as Lucky. Palak Tiwari

leaves a strong emotional imprint as Sanobar. Add Nakul Roshan Sahdev, Kritika Bharadwaj, Yograj Singh and Ayesha Raza Mishra to the mix and the series feels packed with characters that genuinely stay with you.

Fresh & immersive cinematography: 'Lukkhe' doesn't just look gritty; it feels alive. The neon-lit frames, saturated colours, handheld shots and chaotic visual energy perfectly capture the unpredictability of its world. What really stands out is how the visuals mirror the characters' mental state, especially in moments shaped by paranoia, substance abuse and emotional

breakdowns. Stylish without losing realism, the cinematography gives the series a sharp, immersive edge.

Heart in a world fuelled by ego & revenge: Amid all the violence, rivalry and chaos, the women become the emotional anchors of the story. Raashii Khanna brings both strength and vulnerability; Palak Tiwari becomes a grounding force that cuts through the chaos, while Kritika Bharadwaj leaves a striking impact with her confident presence. Their choices actively shape the narrative, making the emotional conflicts hit much harder.

Raw & emotionally charged story: The most interesting thing about 'Lukkhe' is that beneath all the chaos and rivalry, the story stays deeply human. The writing explores ambition, loyalty, addiction, ego and survival without making anything feel overdone or glamorised. Nobody here is entirely good or bad. Every character carries emotional baggage, every decision has consequences and even in its loudest moments, the series never loses the emotional pulse at its core.

